Let Me Ride

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44399443.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Racing, Street Racing, (Separately), Motorcycles, Modern AU but still Canon Species, Exes, Getting Back Together, "Hook-Up", while we're at it, "Coping" Mechanisms, Jealousy, Smut, Strap-Ons, Bratting, POV Adora (She-Ra)

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Catradora AUs by n7punk

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Summary

When Adora left street racing behind to go legit, she lost Catra in the process. The success and clean conscience of being free from her debt to the chop shop have done nothing to replace the girl she loves. After a year of them both trying to fill the void the other left with errant hook-ups and qestionable coping methods, they meet again in the club. No one else can replace what they have together, so Catra decides to come home with Adora for µst one night.
For ƕst one”night.
(The motorcycle racing/chop shop hook-up AU. Ɩsten, µst go with it)

Notes

t’ s the Wombats’ fault.
Welcome to my hyper-specific kitchen sink AU. Mentions of sleeping around while broken up, if that bothers you, but it was very much an ended relationship and also not a secret.
f you’re looking for a fic where they’re well-adµsted, look elsewhere lmao.

The Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

One day, Adora is going to figure out how to be normal. She's going to get a job that doesn't involve risking her life on a regular basis for an adrenaline rush and some adoration, and she'll move into her own house—well, apartment probably, if she can find one where her drums won't bother her neighbors—and, oh yeah, she'll figure out how to process her emotions without the vibration of an engine in her blood or bass thrumming through her body to help it along. As it is, it seems like every other night she needs to either be out on the race track or surrounded by music. When things are quiet and still, nagging thoughts, anxiety, and frustration starts building up.

Angella doesn't just let Adora have her run of the track whenever she wants it though, and she's not supposed to race through the streets unsanctioned anymore. She ends up releasing her aggression by slamming the shit out of her drum set regularly, losing herself in the noise. She's just lucky all that "practice" has added up to her being pretty good, or Glimmer might actually kill her for all the noise she makes out in the yard. Even the noise—and the work out, and the reverberations running through her chest like an engine purring and ready to go—sometimes aren't enough.

That's how she ends up *here* like clockwork, totally failing at that normalcy thing when her own music isn't enough and she needs to be surrounded by it like a heartbeat. It took her awhile to find this club, but it's her go-to for any night when she needs to lose herself. It's hard to hear anything but the steady beat of way-too-fast music. It enters her body and surrounds her in the air. Even better, everyone who goes here *knows* there's no use in trying to talk, so they don't.

You can dance, or you can get drunk and wallow in silence at the bar, but the volume seems to deter all but the most masochistic drunks. Adora has had a few shots here over the last year and she always regretted the way it gave the music too sharp of an edge even for her, who usually *likes* it to hurt. Besides, she needs to be sober for what she really comes here for. The music and dancing is enough to exhaust her on its own by the end of a night, but there are other ways she can end the night. Because there's never an attempt to talk with dance partners, well.I f you're looking for something no-strings-attached, this is the place.

Adora shows up with her dyke bracelet on about every other week, in whatever her gayest outfit is that isn't in the wash at the moment, and makes her way through the dance floor until either she's tired, she's gotten frustrated with flirty guys ignoring the *literal* warning label on her wrist in sunset block letters, or she finds an appropriate dance partner. Sometimes –at least half the time she finds someone, honestly –they just dance.

Sometimes they don't. There's more than one reason for Glimmer to be annoyed with her noise.

She has a rule not to go more than once a week, and now she's a little further from falling apart and more into established coping mechanism territory, she even tries to make two weeks her minimum, but the longest that her drums and limited bike time have been enough for her since… *everything* has been four weeks and two days. She knows, because Bow erased the 5 days sense ~~our~~ Adora's last nonsense" whiteboard on the fridge in the main house the next morning while Glimmer gave her judgy looks. The board has since been returned to the list of groceries and house supplies they need that it was before Adora moved in, but it certainly cowed her at the time.

Back then, she thinks Bow and Glimmer were hoping she'd grow out of it or something. She hasn't, even if she wants to. It' s better than letting the irritation prickle under her skin. She didn't used to have these issues –she used to have a surefire way to ease any stress

she was under – but she wouldn't call it an anger problem, not really . Sometimes it's too much energy and no outlet. Sometimes it's stress. Sometimes it's just the absence of the hum that used to undercut her life. Sometimes it's longing she needs a distraction from. Sometimes she's just horny . There are a lot of reasons for her to end up at *The Crimson Waste*, and tonight is mostly the latter.

A year ago, Glimmer and Bow thought she was spiraling. She kind of was. Now she's just a bit of a fuckboy . Society would call her *lifestyle* or whatever unhealthy, but that's just bullshit heteronormative standards. She doesn't need to settle down and have a "normal" career. Going dancing doesn't hurt anybody – at worst, it' s bad for her hearing, but it's also good exercise, so maybe that cancels it out – and she always doublechecks to make sure anyone she brings home hasn't been drinking. She feels *good* afterwards, and she feels even better when they stay for breakfast and she gets to have a chat with them in the morning while she cooks.

God, she's fucking delusional. Yes, all of that is true, and yes, the societal expectations are bullshit and somebody should be free to live the way she does without it being considered pathetic – she is, though. She likes when her hookups stay over because it feels like *something*, but she likes when they leave afterwards even more because she could never, ever commit to anything – that is, anything with anyone else but the love of her life, who isn't even *in* her life anymore.

f Catra were still here, she would go at her drum set a lot less – more often she would *play* it like a normal person, doing it for the music and not trying to master the fastest songs she can find to push herself to her limits and block out all other thoughts in the process – and maybe she would still like to dance occasionally, but fuck, she might prefer slow dances in the kitchen to the nights when she runs herself ragged and those meaningless mornings after. She knows what she wants, but she isn't getting it, so she ends up at the Waste because it's the best she can get.

t's settling, but she usually feels good enough in her day-to-day , so she would qualify it as *working*. f her way of dealing was something like painting daisies in the park, no one would bat an eye. At most, the only people she is hurting are Glimmer and Bow, and that's mostly their eardrums. A little emotional turmoil in the past, maybe, but they've figured out how to – and she' s quoting here – "domesticate her ," which is to say they've all found the closest thing to a happy medium you can get with such a ragtag trio of friends. They didn't understand her when they first met, but they've learned over time that she's just dif ferent – *apparently*, because back when it was her and Catra she never seemed quite as weird – but they've come to accept the parts of her that didn't absolutely need to be filed down.

(Adora still misses the engine Catra built for her so lovingly being a part of her street bike, but there's road regulations and all that. Glimmer and Bow managed to convince her that when you're kind of famous for racing, people actually pay attention to what you're driving off the track. Her bike was far from street legal before. Adora has learned to make concessions for the sake of not running in with the cops or giving her friends heart attacks.)

She feels more at peace on the dance floor, a steady beat reverberating through her body to keep her grounded. She still isn't a great dancer, but she's gotten to a solid okay, maybe even a little good, over the past year. She moves through the crowd as much as she dances, though, looking for a girl that looks receptive. Honestly, she'd be happy with just dancing tonight. A fleeting moment of connection and a body against her own sounds nice. She misses meaning and real emotion, but she isn't looking for it, not with anybody but Catra.

She saw Starla back near the entrance. She was dancing with her sister at the time, her brother absent and likely being a responsible adult while leaving their older sister on babysitting duty, but she's probably open to dancing with Adora too. Not in the way Adora wants to dance right now, but it might be enough to wear her out so

she can go home with her head silent. She needs to do *something*, because dancing on her own is just a chance to get absorbed in the thoughts she's trying to outrun tonight, the *what if*s and *I miss her*s that still haunt her too often.

There's a magicat to her right. Adora spots her out of the corner of her eye, because Catra's the only thing she can think about today – or in general. Adora shouldn't, but she assesses what she can using just her periphery. The magicat's back is turned and she's dancing with a scorpioni, which tells Adora all it needs to. She should turn away. She should go find Starla and settle for the night.

She can't settle for less than everything she's ever wanted.

She looks different, Adora muses, as she slips between bodies and watches Scorpia spot her over Catra's shoulder. She cut her hair short at some point since Adora last saw her, but she's wearing the same leather jacket she had on the last time she ran into her on a night out, and the dark look on Scorpia's face would assure Adora that it's the same magicat even if she hadn't memorized Catra's outline a long time ago.

The look warns Catra, too, because when Adora slides up behind her and places her left hand on her hip, Catra doesn't even glance down at the bracelet Adora usually leads with as both a warning and question. *Are you okay with this* is a pointless question between them now. Catra tilts her head up, not looking at Adora but letting her glimpse enough of her face to catch the edge of her smirk as she leans back against her, molding their bodies together in an instant.

Just so you can appreciate everything you'll never have, princess, Catra said the last time they stumbled out of the club after crossing paths on the floor. The first time, she turned away and disappeared long before they could hope to make it out to the parking lot, but on the second she actually let Adora dance with her for some reason, and even though she was clearly annoyed with Adora trying to follow her out afterwards, she told her to fuck off out on the pavement without making too much of a scene, which was kind of shocking.

Maybe it was just that Adora was too fragile at the time to pick up the shattered pieces of her pointless hope that had begun to blossom as Catra moved against her. As soon as Catra turned and told her she hated her, Adora stopped dead in her tracks and Catra walked away. f Adora had kept pushing, it probably would have turned out worse. She's still probably going to do it tonight if Catra lets her, though.

Catra certainly isn't opposed to being near her for now, at least as long as they're surrounded by strangers and music. Adora follows her lead as she rolls her body with the beat, alive and almost restless beneath her hands. Adora feels the same way, it's why she's *here* – in the club, and pressed up against Catra with Catra's new not-girlfriend glaring daggers at her over her shoulder.

Catra tilts her head back, almost against Adora's shoulder, and Adora turns her face towards her to feel the soft fur of Catra's ear against her cheek and to puff hot breaths against her neck. She knows how any kiss or bite on Catra's neck turns her on – Adora's the same way, to be honest – and feeling breath against it might as well be foreplay for Catra. Adora wouldn't dare kiss her neck now, not with *don't you get it, I fucking hate you* still hanging in the air between them from last time, and not in the middle of a club when they haven't even looked at each other yet, but she takes satisfaction in the subtle shiver it sends through Catra.

She wanted a distraction and this is the furthest thing from it, but as long as they don't end this night with Catra spitting vitriol at her again, it will probably be fine. She can't pull herself away when she has Catra beneath her hands – this is the exact thing she wanted, that she *always* wants – and Catra doesn't seem inclined to stop either. Maybe she's purring – maybe Adora's using the buzz of the bass to delude herself – but Adora definitely isn't imagining how Catra is draping herself back against her and rolling their bodies together with every movement.

She wasn't dancing this suggestively when Adora first spotted her, she's sure, even if she didn't get a good look at her. Scorpia is glowering, but if knowing how Catra feels about her couldn't stop

Adora, upsetting Scorpia definitely isn't going to. It's maybe a little awkward, but some horrible part of Adora is jealous of the other woman's presence in Catra's life and pleased to have made her jealous in return.

Catra seems to grow bored. She manages to turn around without ever leaving an air gap between them, turning away from Scorpia and settling against Adora's front so they can *rock* together, moving as one. Adora takes her in greedily, happily pulling her in tight against her, but they're close enough they really can't make eye contact and Catra isn't looking at her anyway, gaze fixed indistinctly over her shoulder and that smug smirk that makes Adora want to kiss her firmly in place. Adora keeps her reaction down to flexing her hands on her and dangerously running one down from her waist, to her hip, and then back up again. Both are places she might touch on a normal dance partner, but she's feeling Catra up and they both know it. Catra is in a crop top. There's a lot to touch.

Catra isn't bothered by it. She arches into the touch and her smirk grows even more lopsided. Adora's thigh is between Catra's – or maybe Catra's thigh is between hers – and she isn't entirely sure when or how that happened, but it seems to be enough for Scorpia to finally turn away with a dour expression, and now that Adora isn't having to *watch* Scorpia glare at them, she feels like she can lose herself in Catra the way she has been wanting to ever since their last rendezvous on the dancefloor .

She doesn't rest their foreheads together, as much as she wants to. It would get in the way of dancing even with their bodies this tight together. It's too intimate, anyway, which is a sad thing to say about their heads touching when Adora is shifting her thigh up to press against Catra, but that's less about emotion and more about *need*. Adora doesn't know why she feels bold enough to do this except that she's pretty sure Catra was the one to shift them together like this.

Catra definitely isn't upset by it, throwing her head back a little and rolling forward to meet her. Adora has done some pretty inappropriate things on the dancefloor before, but she's pretty sure

this one is the most offensive. Or maybe it just feels that taboo because it's Catra and they're in *shambles*. She feels like she's burning up, introspection and higher thinking beyond her. In a way, this is distracting her from her earlier depression spiral better than anything she's ever tried before. It will likely leave her *lower* when Catra decides she's done toying with her, but right now she's worked up and beyond caring.

She ducks her head down and ghosts her breath against Catra's neck again. Again, it feels more intimate and dangerous than the way their bodies are locked together, but Catra doesn't stop moving so neither does Adora, even if staying with the rhythm is at the edges of her dancing ability with the two of them this close together. The next roll of Catra body brings her forward, enough for Adora's lips to brush against her neck, but either Catra doesn't feel it or it doesn't end the world like it feels like it should because she doesn't react, at least not in a way that Adora can detect with the noise pounding around and through them.

Fuck it.

Adora kisses her neck, dirty but soft, because Catra's all but *grinding* on her and she did come here planning to hook up, after all. The last time they danced together, things got hot like this, it just took a *lot* longer. This isn't unprecedented. Adora felt like she was losing her mind the entire time. Now she doesn't try to think, just follows Catra's body and her own desires. It feels so good when Catra's hands tighten on her and she tugs her as if to bring them closer together.

They can't get any closer than they already are. They would need to get horizontal to increase the pressure between their bodies, or at least find a wall to pin one of them against. Adora would like that. It would be monumentally stupid, but she would like it. Has daydreamed about it, even, in between the fantasies of Catra coming home and them moving into a house together like they planned when they were eight. Adora tries to pull her head back enough to meet Catra's eyes, or at least to see her face and assess, but Catra doesn't let her.

Catra hooks a hand behind her head and pulls her back close against her neck. Adora knows an invitation when she gets one and she couldn't begin to deny this. She closes her eyes and kisses Catra again, not just once but trailing the kisses down the line of her throat, nuzzling underneath the collar of her warm leather jacket and taking a risk on a light nip half-hidden from view – as if anyone is looking, or they'd be fooled by the obstruction of the collar if they were.

Catra arches against her. Adora is burning up inside, her heartbeat replaced by the bass. Everything she wants is almost within reach for the first time – well, fourth if you count their previous rendezvouses, which Adora certainly doesn't given how they ended – in over a year . She still doesn't know why Catra toys with her like this when they meet. She says it's to show Adora what she's missing, but she doesn't believe Catra would do this if she didn't want to – she *can't*. She has to believe that's an excuse Catra tells her, and maybe even herself.

Catra has to enjoy this just as much as Adora does. Sure, it *hurts*, but everything hurts all the time now and this is one of the better ways it can hurt. Any moment Catra is against her is a good one. It isn't limited to just the two club meetups. There was the time – only once – when Catra showed up to the racetrack. They talked for about a minute, fought for about five, then made out for just as long before they stumbled their way towards Adora's bike and Catra caught a glimpse of it. The next five minutes of fighting were far worse than the previous, and Catra stormed off afterwards. She nearly got in trouble with security on the way out and by the time Adora had explained things – well, made up some bullshit to get them to back down – Catra was long gone.

Adora tightens her grip on Catra's hips and kisses her way back up her neck. She doesn't want to fight tonight. She would *love* to talk some sense into Catra, but she's kind of afraid that's never going to happen, so for the moment she's happy enough to leave it at this: Catra's body against her own and neither of them yelling. As torn up

as Adora's heart is – and as worked up as her *body* is – something inside her feels peaceful with her lips brushing against the edge of Catra's jaw and bass reverberating through them both.

She weighs the pros and cons of trying to kiss Catra. She would kind of love to, and she's sure Catra would let her if she plays her cards right, but it might be too quick. Then again, Catra is encouraging her to kiss her neck. Then *again*, Adora can satisfy herself just with that for a little while. She feels desperately hungry for Catra, but this is already better than anything she was expecting tonight. Just dancing with Catra – as lewd as it is – does more for her than meeting a nice, or hot, or bitchy girl and taking her home. It doesn't matter who she found: if it wasn't Catra, then it wasn't going to feel like this.

Adora takes the risk on lifting her head and trying to make eye contact again. She wants to establish *some* communication so she can get a read on where Catra is at, but she also can't seem like she's trying to actually talk or she'll scare Catra off. Catra doesn't try to stop her from pulling back this time, but she doesn't meet Adora's gaze either. She is looking over her shoulder, her eyes slightly narrowed as she tracks *something*. Her expression is cocky like before, but focused. Adora half expects Scorpia to appear over her shoulder and Catra to laugh in Adora's face as Scorpia pulls her out front for a fight, but instead the impossible happens.

Catra makes eye contact with her. *Meaningful* eye contact.

It's time to go. Catra doesn't have to say it, and Adora probably wouldn't hear it. A year isn't enough time for them to forget each other – not an *ounce* of Adora has forgotten a single thing about Catra – and they can still communicate silently like they learned to while ducked behind cars with cop cars driving past. Maybe Scorpia really is coming back and Catra hasn't had her fun yet. Maybe a bouncer or something spotted them nearly fucking on the dance floor and is on their way over. Maybe Catra just recognized someone from the Horde who could cause problems for *both* of them if they were seen together. Whatever the reason, Catra is leaving and she's expecting Adora to follow her – *inviting* her to.

Adora isn't going to wait around to find out why. It feels like a loss to pull apart, but Catra lets Adora grab her hand as she goes back to pretending – Adora *hopes* – that she doesn't want to look at her. Catra pulls through the dance floor and Adora follows as closely as she can, knowing that if they get separated in the crowd Catra is *not* going to wait for her. Adora is pretty sure Catra is leading her away to get up to something, and it's something she has no doubts Scorpia would happily provide Catra if she asked. Adora isn't going to give her the opportunity to fill her space.

It gets markedly easier to breathe when they get off the practically humid dancefloor. Maybe she's just really gay and likes watching the sway of Catra's hips as she leads her through the front of the club, but not being surrounded by the crush of strangers makes her straighten out her shoulders. Catra snorts when she glances back at her just before they reach the door and notices how different she's walking. Okay, so maybe she's posturing a *little* bit, but Catra definitely found the worst opposition of a rebound for Adora to go up against and she feels like she has to do her best to match up if she doesn't want Catra to walk away again.

Scorpia has muscle Adora just isn't capable of carrying, not to mention the extra foot she has on her, and oh yeah, she didn't "grow a conscience" and go straight like Adora. Entrapta says she's really nice and eager, but Adora is too jealous of her to care about how nice she might be. What she does have that she desperately hopes Scorpia does not have much of is experience with Catra. She has proven that she doesn't always know the right words to say, but she at least knows how to touch her, and she knows that's what Catra wants when she tugs her hand harshly to pull Adora against her – and likely, off balance. She looks amused by Adora stumbling as she catches herself on Catra's waist, anyway.

"You could have *asked*," Adora points out as they walk out past the entrance line. She would have been more than happy to wrap her arm around Catra at the slightest indication that Catra wouldn't consider it an offense, but Catra just sniffs and looks down the

street. Of course she didn't ask. She'd rather *make* Adora do it. Adora has always liked that about her, though, so for a moment she just takes a minute to think *wow* as she feels Catra breathing against her and waits for Catra to tell her what the hell they're doing. The city corner is usually far from quiet, but a silent whine dulls all the street noise to her, leaving it distant and staticky compared to the music still ringing through her ears from the club.

"I assume you rode here?" Catra says, and *oh*, okay, they're doing this. Catra doesn't just want an angry make out this time. Catra scoffs, likely in response to Adora's breath hitching, but Adora *wasn't expecting this*. She tightens her arm around Catra, a precaution as much as it is because she's suddenly feeling a *lot* bolder. She's definitely standing taller now as she nods and turns her head to indicate down the street.

"My street bike's in a lot two blocks over," Adora tells her. Catra flicks an ear and turns her body that way, which is as good of an *I want to go home with you* as Adora is going to get, but she's smirking as she starts to lead them down the street. Scorpia is probably still back inside the club, wondering when Catra is going to be done. She's going to be waiting up and Adora doesn't feel the slightest bit sorry for her – though as someone who has missed Catra desperately, she knows exactly what Scorpia will be feeling when she realizes Catra slipped through her fingers for the night.

"Is Melog around?" Adora asks, because it seems like the safest thing she can ask about or even say as they reach the end of the block and have to wait for the light to change to cross. Catra could easily just follow her home on Melog, but she hasn't mentioned her own bike and Adora can't imagine her abandoning Melog anywhere overnight. Both of Catra's ears twitch at once, and then they fix forward again like nothing happened. Adora doesn't know what that means.

"Melog's stashed right now. I rode with Scorpia," Catra says, side-eying her. A smirk twitches at her lips, definitely smug over Adora's reaction. She doesn't know *quite* what her reaction is, but she

doesn't need to see her own face to know her jealousy is obvious. To Catra, she would bet her immediate determination to get Catra to ride back with her is just as visible. Totally necessarily, Adora pulls Catra a little closer as they start walking again. It was to encourage her to start following her now the light has changed. Of course.

She's jealous, okay, but Catra isn't any better – actually, usually she's worse – so she doesn't seem inclined to complain. Actually, they're both a little fucked up and from the spark in Catra's eyes Adora is pretty sure she likes Adora's reaction. She remembers the look in Catra's eye when she confronted Adora about "moving on" back at the track, as if Adora had been the one to dump and block her. This probably feels like revenge to Catra. Actually, she doesn't look nearly manic enough for that. She's just getting off on it.

They haven't even *started* down that path, but Adora knows they're going to. As long as she doesn't piss Catra off too much before then, anyway. Catra will probably annoy her too, but her door is always going to be open for Catra no matter what happens between them, so it's down to Catra if they do this or not. Adora's tongue darts out to wet her lips as she tries to think of what she wants to say and what is *safe* to.

"Are we going to my place?" she settles on. Catra sends her a *no shit* look that has Adora rolling her own eyes and shifting to pinch – lightly – at Catra's hip, which earns her a surprised hiss and a glare. "As opposed to yours or a hotel. I'd *love* for you to say how badly you want to fuck me, but-" She's cut off by Catra hissing and shoving a hand in her face. It's so familiar, it makes Adora laugh as she ducks beneath Catra's arm to get close again, wrapping both her arms around Catra's waist. As she straightens, pulling Catra in close against her with their fronts together this time, she grins up – and then down – at Catra's embarrassed flush. Catra has something approaching a grimace on her face from trying to scowl over a smile, but Adora knows that look by now so it doesn't fool it her.

She isn't deterred by Catra pretending to put distance between them. She feels a bit breathless as she slides one hand up Catra's back.

She wraps her hand around the base of Catra's head, holding her steady so she can lean their foreheads together. With Adora holding her close, Catra allows it despite the intimacy. Maybe she only lets her do it because it hides her not-smile from Adora's view, but Adora feels an electrified excitement thrum through her body with Catra wrapped in her arms. They're almost as tight together as they were on the dancefloor – if they were actually that close out on the sidewalk, they might get arrested for indecency – and Adora's body doesn't know what to do with Catra in her arms again.

"I *know* you don't treat your other hook-ups like this. Take me home already," Catra huffs, shifting a little but not actually pulling away. Adora frowns, a little put out, but she pulls back, sliding the hand that was on Catra's head down, intending to keep it wrapped around her waist as they walk, but she pauses not even halfway to her goal. She has already taken a half step back and she watches Catra shoot her an annoyed look as Adora freezes halfway through pulling away to a normal distance. Catra shrugs her off, forcing Adora's hand to fall as Catra turns to keep making her way down the street.

"Wait, hang on-" Adora hurries to take a step forward, grabbing Catra's shoulder to halt her.

"I don't want to stand here- What are you doing?" Catra gets halfway through snapping at her before Adora's hand finds the back of her neck again, dipping beneath the collar of her jacket and finding it feels *wrong*, bare skin knotted up. Adora didn't feel it when shifting her hands up because the collar covered it well, but sliding *down* her hand slipped beneath it for a moment. Catra's expression is annoyed and quizzical for a moment when she looks back at Adora, and then Adora watches her eyes widen as she seems to realize what Adora found.

Catra shrugs her off again, and this time Adora lets her, now knowing she was right but not knowing *why*.

"What happened?" she asks. Her hearing still hasn't equalized, but it was getting closer to normal and her voice sounds especially odd

now. Catra scowls, looking forward again with her tail lashing behind her. She reaches up, bringing the front of her jacket together and zipping it up. It isn't a true motorcycle jacket, but it will still be a hell of a lot more protective than her ripped jeans. Adora had her hands on them earlier – they're thin and stretchy. They'll shred if they actually get in an accident.

"Got stabbed in the back – literally. Scar's still fresh," Catra says, voice still gruff. Adora gapes. She takes a step to bring them side-by-side on the sidewalk so she can see Catra's face, but Catra takes a matching step forward. Adora tries it again and Catra keeps going, walking on and forcing Adora to follow.

"Who? When? How are you still *walking*?" Adora demands. Catra hisses at her, but Adora isn't going to *calm down* until she gets like, six more answers. *Stabbed.* In the neck! It's clearly been long enough to scab over, but she can't believe Catra is just brushing this off.

"It takes more than that to kill me. I was faster than him even with a pen knife in my neck. Outsped the cops too," Catra says, throwing her a smirk. They've taken enough steps now for Adora to have caught up to Catra's side – if Catra wanted to stay ahead of her she would have needed to start running with how determined Adora was – so Adora can see the look on her face, cocky but probably faking it at least *some*.

"What, did someone catch you jacking their car?" she asks, before immediately pausing to glance down the street when they reach another corner, but there isn't anyone too close and they aren't paying attention to them anyway. Catra scoffs, her tail lashing in disapproval.

"Please, that kind of thing would happen to *you*. Cops showed up when I was supposed to be delivering my new racer. Buyer freaked out and assumed I snitched. Pretty sure he ended up getting arrested and I didn't even have to slow him down first. It was pathetic on everyone's part except mine, really," Catra returns. Adora's face

is red. She's dealing with sudden anxiety on top of an immediate reaction to Catra being like *this* – capable, and most of all, cocky – plus the firestorm of emotions she has surrounding Catra in general right now. Her body doesn't really know how to react, so it seems to default to wanting Catra desperately. She wants to get her hands on Catra to ensure there's no other grievous wound on her as much as she just wants to touch her , but Catra seems to preen under the attention.

"I can't believe you're brushing this off." *I can't believe you didn't call me*, she really means. Sure, they haven't really talked over the last year, but the size of the scar tells Adora that it was far worse than just a clean stab. An injury like that could have left Catra paralyzed. She isn't surprised Catra didn't want her help – even if she's kind of hurt by it – but she can't believe Catra didn't tell her something like this happened. Catra scowls, her ears pinning back and arms crossing, but she keeps walking by Adora's side as she turns the corner to lead them towards the lot where she parked.

"Don't give me a speech," Catra snaps. Adora opens her mouth and then closes it. She didn't launch into a speech about *recklessness* or whatever else Weaver would have said when Catra limped back home and she wasn't planning too. She's just upset that they aren't in the kind of place where Catra would tell her if she nearly died. She thought that would be a *given*.

"I didn't say anything." That earns her a flat glare. Catra does not look happy with her, and yet she follows her as the chain-link fence around the lot looms ahead and Adora slips a hand into her pocket to grab her lot ticket. Catra's still planning on coming home with her – for the moment, at least.

"I can see you getting all high and mighty again. *This is what you get for working with the Horde, blah blah*. Keep your mouth shut and you might actually get to fuck me," Catra returns. Adora blinks at the sidewalk in front of her and then turns her head to blink at Catra too as if that will make her words make more sense. Catra is being perfectly clear, she's just also being *wrong*. She knows how bitter

Catra is over Adora leaving the street crew behind, but not committing crimes doesn't equal being an awful person to those who do – especially not her *girlfriend*. Ex-girlfriend. Fuck, she hates that word.

"You don't deserve it. No one does," Adora replies. Catra has never deserved the shit she has gotten and she always deserved *better*. Catra's tail lashes behind her and she quickly looks away, staring out into the street and not breaking stride. If Adora tried to do that she would walk into something or trip on the pavement, but Catra has no difficulty. It's clearly easier than meeting Adora's eyes.

"Weaver definitely does," she replies. Adora pauses.

"Well, okay," she has to concede. Catra laughs – like, *actually* laughs, casual and real – and looks back to her. The tension leaks out of her with the laugh, and though she looks far from carefree, the fight has been avoided – for the moment, at least.

Weaver is why they're like this. They were both street rats when she took them in. They were raised in the garage, which was part illegal car modification and part chop shop. They always knew they were criminals – they *did* go to school, after all, so as much as Adora has recently learned that they were isolated, there was only so much Weaver could do without putting in the effort of teaching them math and biology herself – but it always felt more illicit than immoral. For a long time they just helped out around the shop and learned about cars, too young be sent to steal things and risk being spotted behind the wheel. When they were teenagers and they got sent out occasionally, Adora would always reason that people have insurance.

Not everyone does. Not everyone can keep their job for the delay until a car is replaced, either. Adora felt bad about it, but it was easier to ignore when she was old enough to really drive and Weaver let her become a street racer, mostly contributing to the shop by giving them a portion of her winnings in exchange for her car parts and maintenance. It was Catra installing all that for her, but

they were indebted to the shop for giving Adora the bike and upgrades in the first place, before she had won anything.

Catra stayed as a mechanic for the shop, at least not responsible for stealing anything and distanced from the cops. Every now and then Weaver or Hordak would have them steal something to remind them of their place –and that they were dirty like the rest of them, so don't get any ideas –but it was rare and things felt better . For Adora. For Catra, she was still in the shop full time, directly under Weaver's thumb. She stayed there even after Adora met Glimmer at a street race she definitely shouldn't have been at and got the closest thing to scouted there is in championship racing.

Street racing was always Catra's passion too, she just was never as competitive at it since Weaver wouldn't finance her bike to start. Weaver already had them hooked in from Adora's debt and didn't need to give Catra a shot at making more money –or being *happy*. Adora still can't fathom why Catra stayed, but she definitely isn't going to lecture her about it now, not when she needs to get her hands on her for multiple reasons. She never wants to *lecture* anyway, she just wants Catra back, and while she has no real delusions of that happening, she's still pretty sure her best chance is taking Catra home and not putting her foot in her mouth before then.

They don't continue the conversation as they reach the parking attendant's booth. They're too close and they didn't make it this far by openly talking about their crimes on the sidewalk. Adora greets the attendant and thanks them for watching her bike as she gives them her ticket while Catra skulks behind her and pretends to be totally uninterested in the exchange and the woman she is going home with. Adora reaches an arm out for her as they walk past the booth and Catra eyes it, giving a sniff of disdain before she makes a show of looking away and letting her next step drift her closer, *allowing* Adora the honor of putting her arm around her waist.

t would be an act if Adora didn't legitimately feel honored. She tightens her arm just to feel Catra against her as she leads her to the corner of the lot where she parked. Catra wrinkles her nose when

she sees her bike – *her* bike, not Adora's, because Catra might as well have built the thing. Adora can fix a bike just fine, but she can't build a racer from scratch, especially not one that tears down the road and swings around corners in a perfect arc. Adora can build an average bike, but Catra can win a race with one without ever stepping foot on the track herself.

She hates what Adora did to her bike. She made that very clear when she caught a glimpse of it on her visit to the track, but Catra's work was as good as it was illegal for the streets, so between Adora and Entrapta they managed to pull parts and ideas out of Catra's bike to retrofit onto Adora's new racing bike while meeting championship restrictions. Now, in Catra's mind, the bike that was once *hers*, that Adora would tear through races with and demolish both records and speed limits on, has been dissembled and stripped down to just Adora' s daily ride.

She gets why Catra feels disrespected. She also thinks that she should at least consider the fact that her work is out there in front of the entire world on the track, even if the bike frame it's attached to is different. Catra isn't willing to give her any consideration, though. Adora grabs her helmet and pauses, glancing between it and Catra. Catra immediately scowls and uncrosses her arms to walk towards the seat.

"Not a chance," she says. Adora twists her mouth, glancing down at the helmet and wondering if this is worth fighting over. She really wants Catra to have a helmet, but this one isn't designed with the extra room inside to protect and cushion her ears. t will probably feel like having her hair pulled the entire time, and one of them will end up without a helmet regardless. She would *really* like Catra to be the one wearing it, but she's pretty sure Catra isn't going to buy the argument that Adora at least has health insurance now.

She sighs as she pulls out her ponytail holder, sliding it onto her wrist and shaking her hair out so she can pull on the helmet. She's a damn good racer. She just has to make sure she doesn't get in an accident. t has been a long time since she had one of f of the track –

and even on the track, she's damn good – so she isn't really worried, but she did just find out Catra was *stabbed* and she would like to take care of her however Catra will allow her to. She isn't going to allow this, though, so Adora swings her leg over the seat and sits uncomfortably far forward on it as Catra settles behind her, uncomfortably far back. This bike wasn't intended for two people, initially, but Catra did make modifications to allow it without too much discomfort or balance issues.

This is far from the first time Catra has wrapped her arms around Adora's waist and pressed against her back. Adora pauses to zip back up her motorcycle jacket – dancing is sweaty work so she had the front pulled back and buckled behind her back to give her as much air as possible, leaving her down to just the sleeves and her tank top with the racing championship logo across the front – which forces Catra to let go for a moment, but with her skin properly covered, Adora leans forward and grabs the handlebars.

As she turns the bike on, Catra settles in properly behind her. Maybe she's getting a tight, safe grip. Maybe she's snuggling against her. Adora isn't going to call her out. She smiles to herself as she flips her visor down and revs the motorcycle for the hell of it. It rumbles through the air and into her chest, sending an electric thrill through her veins. It's the rhythm of her life, a feeling she associates with all kinds of endorphins. On the large scale, there's races and the adrenaline of winning or coming damn close. Smaller scale is her drums, sound reverberating through her and the air.

Even smaller, but more monumental than all of the above, is Catra's purr rolling through both their chests as they lay together, not a layer of fabric between them to dampen the transmission of that treasured rumble. The faster they get home, the faster she gets that again. She *is* going to be a safe – and legal – driver when she takes Catra home, but she gives herself the small present of tearing out of the parking spot way too fast for the average driver. This is nothing compared to the maneuvers she pulls on the track, so she has total

confidence in it, but she drives out of the lot at more normal speeds after that.

Catra's arms tightened around her as she pulled out. They slacken again as they hit the street. Adora frowns to herself as they make it down two blocks driving –at the speed limit, even –behind cars before a light stops them. Idling as they wait, Catra seems to lean back behind her. She probably isn't, really –there isn't enough room on the bike for her to do that without risking a fall –but in comparison to that small, thrilling moment as the wind sprung to life around them and Catra wrapped around her, this feels *distant*.

She revs the engine. Catra leans a little closer.

She said she would be a safe driver. And really, it's safe if you're very good and know you won't get in an accident, right? Even racing through the streets, she's safer than some of the bad –or just middling –drivers on the road.

This is her wild side, the side Glimmer and Bow have been trying to get her to water down. She knows they have a point, but when the light turns green, she lets loose the throttle and swings her bike to the side, slipping between the cars and shooting out in front of them. She crosses out of the intersection before the car in front's bumper reaches it.

Behind her, Catra whoops. Adora laughs as the wind whips around them, wrapping around her body as tightly as Catra's arms do. The pounding in her heart is worth any road violations. Besides, the cops would have to catch them to ticket her. And best of all, it won't take them long to get home. Well, maybe not best of all. As much as she can't wait for Catra's soft sighs –if she can earn them –her laugh of joy as they swing through the streets is just as beautiful, and they're something she wasn't expecting to get to hear again.

She may have gone legit, but no one will ever be able to take this part out of her. This is the part she and Catra share. It's the core of her very being.

Chapter End Notes

Happy Birthday Adora Ihope you like birthday sex uwu Although it’s more like the birthday Promise of sex since the smut isn’t until next chapter lmao
Chapter count is entirely an estimate because Im still not sure how this is going to be spaced out. Also it was supposed to be 20k and Im at like 16k writing chapter 2 so.don’t expect me to know what Im doing with my life, or with numbers in general.

Emotional Support Strap

Chapter Notes

> Not really a CW, but mentions of other partners in bed and a lot of brat behavior in bed that involves "playing hard to get," but it is very much playing and both parties involved know that. Also clawplay.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

With Adora racing, it doesn't take them long to reach home. She slows to a normal speed as she rides down the narrow street that runs between the backs of the properties in Glimmer's neighborhood. Catra's arms loosen around her as Adora takes the offshoot from the main driveway that leads to her small guest house in the back corner of the double lot, but Catra doesn't let go when Adora pauses to open the garage, only getting off the bike when Adora has parked inside.

"Good to know being domesticated didn't make you boring," Catra comments with her signature, infuriating smirk as she climbs off Adora's bike and does a small turn to take in the dinky garage. The house could pass for a large apartment and the garage is smaller than your average shipping container. Catra looks back over her shoulder as Adora pulls off her helmet and hangs it off the bike handles, a little too eager to put it away properly now. The ride home was probably the fastest she's gone on city streets since switching to the pro circuit, but she certainly isn't going to tell Catra that when she's smiling at her.

"You're so lucky I've already seen your real garage, because this is pathetic," Catra adds. Adora snorts as she steps forward, crowding behind Catra. Her hands are attracted to Catra's waist like a magnet, a bolt of desire running through her at having Catra in her hands—in *private*, where anything could happen—like this. She is well aware

how much Catra would judge her if she thought this was what Adora left for – it's a downgrade and she knows it, though the garage at the track is such an upgrade it can't even be compared – but for once, bikes and racing are the furthest thing from Adora's mind.

For the ride home, Catra kept one arm very firmly anchored around her waist. That would have been enough to get her excited, but Catra's other hand, despite also hanging on tight, wandered more. Adora's jacket is heavy-duty – which is to say , appropriate for riding, unlike Catra's whole outfit – but her jeans have a little more lenience in the weave to facilitate dancing, and Catra definitely splayed her fingers down over them a few times, aware from the past that Adora would barely feel her touch over the jacket. t wasn't that much of sensation through her jeans, really , but the mental game got to Adora just like she is sure Catra intended it too.

"Pretty sure you didn't come here for my garage," Adora points out. Her voice is low and throaty, but she's pretty sure it's her lips ghosting against Catra's ear that makes her shiver. Catra has a satisfied air to her as she arches back against Adora, slotting their hips together. She makes a considering hum, like she just might reject Adora. There's a shivering excitement twitching her tail against Adora's leg. She's toying with her – or , just maybe, she wants to be toyed with. She did say earlier – indirectly – that she wanted Adora to fuck her.

"No, I came here because you took the good strap with you," Catra decides, tone conversational. Adora barely has a moment to process that before Catra turns. She flashes Adora a smirk as she grabs the front of her jacket, pulling her down into a kiss. Adora's blood lights on fire, her arms wrapping around Catra and an embarrassingly early moan slipping out as they kiss, open-mouthed and dirty, not an ounce of doubt left about Catra's intent.

t has been so long since they kissed like this, scorching with promise. Adora has a deep hunger for Catra that she pours into the kiss. More importantly, Catra gives it *back*, releasing the smallest sound as she presses in like it isn't enough and nips at her bottom

lip. It feels delicious for Catra's fangs to sink into her again. Adora has had some filthy kisses since their breakup – even a few with Catra, back at the track – but they were all meaningless compared to this. Catra is in her arms and her *home* this time. Catra is about to be hers, and even if they're still fighting in general, they aren't in this moment. Those last kisses were fiery *because* they were fighting, but these are fueled by pure desire.

Catra's hands release the front of her jacket, and then it's just happening, zippers and buckles coming undone until both their jackets are slipping off their shoulders. Adora's ends up vaguely thrown over the bike – though she takes no time to make sure it won't fall in the next few seconds – and Catra drops her jacket on the small workbench by the door after Adora has backed her towards it. They have to part to remove their clothes, but Catra's hands slip under her shirt immediately after as Adora fumbles with the garage lock.

Not having her hands or lips on Catra is excruciating even if she has her nearly pinned between her and the door that she's now wishing she hadn't locked. The door pops open and then they're kissing again, stumbling into the hallway. Catra doesn't pull back or look around, letting Adora's hands on her steer her as much as they feel her up. Vaguely, in the back of her mind, Adora makes a note to be proud that despite everything Catra trusts her to take care of her and that her space will be safe, but right now she's busy gripping Catra's thighs and lifting her up.

Catra hops up and locks her ankles together behind Adora's back without hesitation, letting Adora wrap her hands around her ass and carry her the few feet left to her bedroom door. Catra is heavier than she looks, but Adora is also *stronger* than she looks and she can already flash her muscles when she wants to. She can't carry Catra far, but the guest house is small and both the garage and her bedroom are off of the entry. It's hard to walk there with Catra's tongue in her mouth, but carrying her might actually make it easier than walking together since only one set of feet has to make it there.

Adora feels her mattress hit her knees and takes a minute to hike Catra up into a better position for setting down – and to enjoy the kiss just a little longer – before she pulls back. A string of spit hangs between them for a moment and then snaps when Adora draws in a heavy breath. Their faces are close and both their eyes are hooded, but Adora can see the raw desire on Catra's face even with her eyes unfocused at this distance.

"The bed's under you," she utters a low warning, seeing Catra's ears perk towards her in her periphery before she bends and lays Catra down on the mattress. If she hadn't warned her, she's pretty sure Catra would have clung on and – despite Catra likely pretending otherwise – there would have been a few moments where she panicked, not knowing what was under her. Catra likes to be taken care of, but she does *not* like to be out of control. As it is, she hangs on for a moment, stiff, but once Adora has laid her down all the way, draping over her awkwardly from the way her waist has to twist with her feet still on the floor, Catra relaxes.

She leans up as her legs and then arms fall away, kissing Adora insistently for a few long seconds before she drops her head back against the mattress and sweeps her gaze down Adora's body. Well, down her face and stopping at her neckline, because Adora is wearing a practically skimpy tank top, tight and white, that only accentuates the black sports bra she's wearing under it. The bra is scooped too low to do much when she's leaned over like this, though, and she knows Catra is getting the exact kind of eyeful that she loves.

Adora has had this bra for three years. She's well-aware it's one of Catra's favorites on her. She throws her a smirk as she pushes back off the bed. Catra narrows her eyes at her for a moment, but then seems immediately appeased when she realizes Adora is reaching down to unlace her boots. Maybe Adora's gaze being fixed down gives her a false sense of security, but every part of Adora is attuned to Catra, so she doesn't miss the small sigh she gives as she sinks back into the mattress. Adora steals a glance up as she pulls off her

first boot and finds Catra with the fight leaked out of her, obviously *content* and not even looking at Adora, her eyes just indistinctly hooded.

She likes being in Adora's bed. It's so obvious, so easy for Adora to see and yet something Catra turns a blind eye to in favor of her bitterness. She has to know it – she is a lot more observant than Adora – but the last few times they met Catra acted like Adora would be doing her a favor if she died. Adora was already planning to make this a night to remember, for Catra to think back on when she's touching herself and missing Adora, but now she wants more than that. Go figure, she always wants more with Catra, but tonight she wants her to make her remember what it's like when it's good – what it could be like again.

She wants to fuck her better than she's ever had in her life. She wants to show Catra that the other girls who have wandered into her life can never treat her the way Adora can. She wants to show her that the girls who have come into *Adora's* life have nothing in comparison to the piece of her that Catra has. Some days it still feels like Catra still has all of her and that's what she intends to give Catra tonight. As she steps back out of her last shoe, she straightens to eye Catra as she reaches for her fly.

"You want the strap?" she asks, because *fuck* would she like to give it to her, and she might as well grab it now. Whatever Catra asked for, she doesn't think she could bring herself to leave the bed once she got into it with Catra. Catra's eyes, languidly wandering up her body, snap to her gaze at the words. Her pupils narrow to slits and her tail *thuds* against the bed in a heavy, excited movement. Adora smirks at her as Catra's tongue peeks out to wet her lips.

"If you still remember how to use it. I won't be as easy to please as your other girls," Catra replies, voice dismissive but her body language *highly* invested. Adora's smirk turns into a crooked smile as she turns towards her bedside drawer. She has no doubts that Catra will make her work for it. Catra props herself up on her elbows to glance down into the drawer Adora opens and then laughs, likely

at her immediate access to her toys, but it's practical. They kept their toys in the dresser at their old apartment, but Catra still has that dresser and Adora uses a closet now. The only reason they didn't before is because their curtain rod was broken.

This place was supposed to be the guest house for Casta when she came to visit her niece – an isolation zone, really , so no one had to deal with her 24/7, and especially not first thing in the morning – and it's appropriately finished. Extended family is best loved when you can sleep in peace and quiet, apparently . Now it's Adora's house and the last time Casta came for a visit she stayed with Angella. Adora's pretty sure Angella encouraged Glimmer and Bow to buy this property exclusively so that *wouldn't* happen, but it's too late now and Adora is entrenched. The guest house is small but a fair bit nicer than their old apartment.

"I'm going to make you work for it too," Adora says, conversationally , just so she can watch how that riles Catra up. A fire lights in her eyes and her tail lashes as Adora pulls out the satin bag she keeps the strap in – which it did *not* come in, it's not nice enough for that, she stole it from a vibrator she bought after the breakup that she found underwhelming – and sets it beside the pillow on the bed. In her moment of distraction, Catra reaches over for Adora's splayed-open jeans. Her eyes previously stuck on the glimpse of Adora' s underwear past the open fly when she was eyeing her up, but now she drags her fingers down, slipping them inside. Adora has an immediate reaction that she *swears* is subtle, but Catra smirks up at her with victory.

"Oh, we both know you're easy . How many girls have you slept with this year, again?" Catra retorts, her fingers hooking and *pressing* against Adora through her underwear. Adora's breath stutters, but she shoots Catra a glare and reaches for her waistband to shove her jeans down the rest of the way .

"Like ten," she answers, tone hot, but Catra kind of deserves to know. Obviously she knows in general, but Adora has never had to get tested before this past year, so she isn't going to act like it

doesn't matter. She's pretty sure she knows the exact number of girls who have been in Catra's bed in that time, her question is really *how often*. Catra's eyes narrow slightly and her tail flicks, but the cocky look on her face doesn't shift. What *does* shift is her fingers, spreading out and scissoring back together because she still knows exactly how to find Adora's clit in a half-dark room, while she's wearing underwear, and at a bad angle.

Adora gasps, and Catra –stupid, sexy , infuriating Catra –chuckles.

"Aw, and none of them knew how to *treat you*, did they? It's okay, I'm sure I can give you a better orgasm in the five minutes before I get bored than any of them ever did," Catra *coos* back at her, dipping her fingers lower to press up against Adora's entrance through her underwear, giving her everything and *nothing* at the same time. Adora's entire body is burning from the heat working through her bloodstream and she can feel how red her face is.

The problem is Catra is probably right. Adora enjoyed her hook-ups, they helped her keep sane in some ways, but she didn't always get off. It wasn't really the point for her and even the orgasms that came to her aren't what Catra can manage with very little effort and a cocky smile. Adora decides it's time she is in the bed and Catra is *naked*. She tugs her tank top off harshly just so she can get at the sports bra underneath. Once her tits are out, Catra's eyes go round and she focuses on them just like Adora knew she would. It lets her shove down her jeans without Catra playing at fucking her through her underwear, making her weak-kneed.

Catra doesn't seem bothered by the change in direction, reaching out to feel her up as Adora places a knee in the bed and swings her leg over Catra to straddle her. Her distraction only works so long before Catra turns it on her, kneading against her chest and pinching her nipple. Adora's breath stutters and she leans down into the touch without thinking about it. Catra looks away from her chest long enough to send her a smirk and then she leans up, nipping hard at the top of Adora's breast before taking her nipple in her mouth.

"Ff fuck," is Adora' s very coherent response to that, her breath ragged and her back arching to press into the warm heat of Catra's mouth. t feels good and it has been way too long. Straddled over Catra's hips, she has some vague pressure against her, not enough but *jµst* enough to remind her it has been a while since she has gotten off and she suddenly, *desperately* needs it right now. Catra's hand that isn't kneading at her other tit slips around her to palm her ass, claws digging in as she tugs Adora closer so she doesn't have to lean up as much.

Adora moans, exactly as easy as Catra insinuated she was going to be, and then she *shouts* when Catra's hand lets go and comes down hard to spank her, making her hips stutter forward and all the air leave her lungs. She feels like she's on *fire* and the only thing that could help would be getting off. She weighs µst letting Catra take care of her to get it out of the way for a moment, but *night to remember* and all that. She knows Catra doesn't want this to be easy, and frankly, neither does she.

She reaches back and grabs Catra's wrist before she can spank her again, even though she would kind of love that. Catra sqirms, probably preparing to get in a better position, and it makes Adora's nipple twist in her mouth µst enough to send a jolt through her without being too painful, but Adora is on a mission even as she pants and stutters her hips forward. She pulls Catra's wrist up and pins it on the pillow. At that moment, Catra realizes what she is doing and pulls away from her chest, sending Adora the same cocky smirk as before, except now Adora is looking down at it framed by her tits, which isn't helping her body calm down.

"Y ou think you can hold me down, princess?" Catra asks, her voice so seductive that it sends a shiver through Adora. Catra started calling her *princess* when she decided to go legit, like Adora did it because she thought she was above the rest of them or something, but at the moment it doesn't feel mocking. Well, mocking in the bad way, at least. Adora has always found it hot when Catra gets a little condescending in bed. She holds Catra's gaze in a challenge, but it

takes her a moment to speak, body worked up enough that she has to draw in a heavy breath first.

"I *know* I can," she replies, watching Catra's eyes burn in response. They both know Adora has done it before. Catra is breathing heavier too, even if she's still clothed and seems less worked up. That isn't right and Adora intends to *fix* it. Before she can, though, Catra twists her arm and yanks her wrist free, slipping from Adora's grip. Adora wasn't expecting it, but she still could have held on if she really wanted to. She isn't pushing that kind of thing right now, though. Catra is challenging her for it, but that isn't the same thing as agreeing to it, at least not yet.

"I think," Catra says, her voice rough and so sexy Adora swears that it could get her off without Catra ever touching her directly, "that you would rather my hands were all over you," Catra finishes, hooking her arms over her shoulders and pulling her down so she can purr the words in her ear. Adora shivers as she feels Catra's claws dig into her back, making her think of the way they rake down it when Adora is fucking her *right*.

"I want you naked. I want to get my hands on you," Adora counters, which isn't a counter at *all*, but she needs it like, yesterday. Both can happen – *fuck*, she wants both to happen, but Catra needs to get naked first. Catra chuckles, but she drops her head back to the pillow and then tilts her chin back.

"W aiting for you to try," she challenges. Adora is already taking the invitation, leaning down to kiss the side of Catra's neck as she shifts to settle her weight back on Catra's hips so her hands can be free to push Catra's shirt up to her armpits, revealing she isn't wearing a bra beneath, which isn't surprising for Catra at all even if it's a risk with a shirt cropped this much. Catra digs her claws into Adora's back and toys with her, arching her back to display her tits but trap the fabric beneath her shoulders so Adora can't pull the shirt all the way off.

Adora knows how to handle Catra when she lives to make things difficult, though. She bites her neck and earns a growling gasp,

everything forgotten for long enough that Adora can pull the shirt – and by extension, Catra's arms – up over her head in the moment of weakness without Catra digging her claws in again. The glimpse of Catra's face that Adora sees before the fabric passes over it reveals she is smirking.

"Dirty," Catra accuses, but she's breathless and basically invited Adora too, so Adora just grins as she leans down to kiss along Catra's neck again. Catra doesn't hesitate to hook her arms over Adora's shoulders again. Catra is just *like* this. They both are, as competitive in bed as they are on the road.

"Getting there," Adora promises, nipping underneath Catra's jaw and being rewarded with an arch of her back that lets Adora slip her hands beneath her. She pulls Catra tight against her without leaving Catra's neck, trailing kisses down it. It's difficult to duck enough to do it when they're this close, but it's so worth it for the slight whine on Catra's breath as Adora sucks a hickey into the side of her neck.

Satisfied Catra isn't going to arch away just for the fun of it right now, she finally gets to squeeze along her curves and feel the muscle that flexes in her stomach – likely just to show off – when Adora runs her hands over it. She wants to touch every inch of Catra, and kiss it too while she's at it. For now, she settles for feeling up and marking her until Catra's claws are digging into her back again and she's squirming.

Adora is pretty sure she's trying to rub up against something, maybe even her own jeans because she is to the point where absolutely anything is worth it right now. She doesn't know that for sure, but she's pretty sure she was *wrong* when she thought Catra seemed more composed. She finally releases Catra's neck and gets to watch Catra lean up for a kiss and then look *betrayed* as Adora sits back on her hips to survey her, ignoring the claws that dig in and try to keep her close. Or at least she tries to ignore them until they inevitably drag down her sides as she pulls away and Adora gasps out, her hips quivering. Catra recovers from her betrayal to send her a cocky smirk and reach for her again.

"Come on, Adora, I know you want me to take you apart," she purrs, which is *true*, it's so true Adora's underwear is completely soaked and she's probably leaving a damp spot on Catra, but Adora is determined to fulfill the promise she made herself and get Catra undressed. She shifts back before Catra can touch her, grabbing Catra's thighs as she moves so she can pull them apart and settle between them. Catra's eyes dilate and her hands fall to grab the sheets for a moment, letting Adora finally undo her fly so she can pull her jeans down.

Catra isn't wearing underwear. It isn't unheard of, but it makes Adora wet her lips as she glances up and finds Catra, despite how turned on she is – her jeans are just as wet as Adora's underwear – sending her another cocky smirk. Adora can see what she has done to Catra, but Catra is seeing what that does to Adora in turn, and that's enough to earn the smirk. Adora absently swears as she pulls the jeans down the rest of the way. They don't come without a fight given how skinny they are, but Catra is laughing at either that or Adora's mouth, so she doesn't make it more difficult by trying to wrap her legs around Adora or something.

Finally, *finally* Adora can toss the jeans vaguely away towards the floor and run her eyes over the length of Catra's naked body. The tip of Catra's tail twitches and her smirk stays in place as Adora drinks in the sight of her, managing to keep her hands off of Catra for a few moments only because she desperately wants to see all of her before she leans in to touch. It lasts for a few seconds at most because her mouth is *watering* and she needs to kiss her again.

Catra wraps her legs around Adora so she can pull her in as Adora shifts up again, apparently having been as passive as she is going to – which is to say, not much at all. Adora kisses her before Catra manages to do it herself, though that might be because Catra is a *little* distracted arching against her and trying to get stimulation despite the bad angle. She growls, hot and frustrated, and nips Adora's lip harshly when it isn't enough. Adora moans, her hands finding Catra's thighs and squeezing for a moment before she starts

to run her hands over her. To her surprise, Catra pulls back from the kiss.

"Nuh uh, if you want to touch me you have to get naked first," Catra chides, her voice smug with victory because she already knows Adora is going to agree to her terms. They're not exactly a *burden*. Adora could point out that she basically already is, but she wants to get back to kissing *immediately*, so she pulls back. Catra releases her, laughing at her eagerness as Adora pushes her underwear down to her knees and awkwardly shifts her weight between them so she can pull it down over each knee individually. It pins Catra's pants somewhere on the floor, Adora already running her eyes over Catra again.

As she leans in, Catra shifts and gets one thigh between her own. The underwear was a *trap*, because the next thing Adora knows Catra is rubbing up against her clit and her entire perception of the world kind of *stutters* in the face of pleasure. She shivers forward, relieved when Catra kisses her again. She gives up on all her plans for a moment, just bracing herself with her forearms on either side of Catra's head and losing herself in finally, *finally* having pressure against her. Catra purrs, and that only makes Adora lose herself more, vibrations rumbling through them both as she desperately rolls her hips back to meet Catra's thigh.

One of Catra's arms is wrapped around her waist and the other is in her hair. Adora becomes aware that is happening when Catra's fingers twist in her hair, pulling Adora up, away from her lips, so she can whisper in her ear. She has to wait a moment while Adora moans, loud and *so fucking far gone*, and in that moment Adora realizes she is on fire again. Catra's arm around her feels almost as hot as the point between her legs.

"Come for me and I'll let you fuck me until I get bored," Catra purrs to her. Adora intends to have Catra just as ruined as Adora is for her now when she gets her hands on her, but she's too desperate to challenge Catra back, instead whining as she nods her agreement,

panting too heavily and moaning too much to agree with words as qickly as she needs to rush them out because, fuck, yes, *please*.

Catra lets out a smug chuckle and then her thigh falls away. Adora has two seconds to be aghast, cold hitting her without Catra's warmth pressed against her, but then Catra's arm leaves her waist and she slips her hand between them. When Catra's fingers find her clit, all other coherent thought whites out. Catra kisses her and it's the messiest kiss they've ever had, Catra all but using her mouth as Adora pants and whines, their tongues meeting and Adora barely able to breathe but never wanting it to stop.

Catra was right. When Adora comes, it's more intense than every other orgasm she's had in the last year combined.

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You'd think Catra would behave for at least as long as it takes Adora to put on the strap-on's harness.

Actually, Adora doesn't know why she thought that.

When she shifts to the edge of the bed so she can pull the loops up her legs without having to undo them entirely, Catra follows her, curving around her back and biting at her shoulders hard enough to leave bruises without any need to latch on. Adora, being who she is, gasps and shifts her hips unconsciously despite having jµst gotten off, which doesn't exactly help with putting on the harness. Catra purrs into the next bite, sending those vibrations that are Adora's lifeblood straight into her.

She yanks on the strap and fumbles through tightening it as fast as she can. Once she has it on, though, Catra pulls back and curls up in one of the least convenient positions she can, sat leaned back

amongst the pillows with her legs curled up under her and her feet tucked in with pretty much no access. Adora *knows* how wet Catra is and she has made it pretty damn clear that she wants Adora to fuck her like this, but she still flashes Adora a smug smile when she sees the indignant look on her face.

"It's cute that you still think I'm going to just roll over for you," Catra comments. Adora releases a short laugh. She has *never* had that thought about Catra, she just assumed she wanted to get off enough at this point that she wouldn't actively make it harder for her. Again, she doesn't know why. She shifts, crawling up the bed so she can lean over Catra. It's awkward given Catra's half-sat up position and the strap between them, but Adora settles kneeling over Catra's thighs with the strap nestled against her so Catra can *feel* what she could be having.

"Funny, usually you like it facedown," Adora returns, smirking down at Catra now that it's her turn to look indignant. Facedown wasn't exactly their standard, but it used to be a fairly regular thing for them. It's how they used the strap the very first time, worried about it hurting and thinking that would be easiest, and she's pretty sure Catra has built an association with it. Catra growls, her tail either lashing and hitting Adora in the process or purposefully swatting at her hip from where it is curled up around her. Adora grins as she leans in, honestly a little surprised that Catra doesn't pull away just to be contrary when Adora nuzzles against her ear.

"Or, you could just let me give you what you want because you're soaking by now and you know how good I feel," she breathes into her ear with a confident chuckle that she knows is going to rile Catra up. The more Catra is worked up, the more likely she is to abandon the brat act. Not that Catra *isn't* a brat, but it's certainly an act that she isn't spreading her legs for Adora right now. Catra growls again, shifting under her to lay back, but it certainly isn't in *defeat*. No, she just needs her arms free so she can wrap them around Adora's back and dig her claws in.

"Stick to shutting your mouth and looking pretty ," Catra grumbles as Adora shivers beneath her claws, gasping out with a desperate edge to it.

"Y ou think Im pretty ," she sing-songs back the moment that she can breathe again. Catra scoffs, but it's a *caught* sound, because how dare Adora repeat her own words back to her. Adora is being a little childish, but Catra is being an *utter brat*, so she thinks it's earned. She's on a mission though and Catra isn't turning this around on her. She uses Catra's new angle to drape fully over her – pressing the strap more firmly against the dip between her thighs in the process – and braces herself on one of her forearms. Catra narrows her eyes at her and drags her claws down her back again, but Adora is expecting it now.

t still ef fects her – it still makes her gasp – but it doesn't stop her from reaching for Catra's ear. Catra's eyes widen for the half second before Adora grabs it and *pulls*, firm and steady. A sharp yank would just hurt Catra, likely earning her a rake with her claws that actually breaks skin, but when Adora does it with steadily building pressure, it makes Catra gasp out and *whine*, her tail lashing and legs unconsciously shifting, first curling up tighter and then straightening out. Adora grins as she releases the pressure and watches Catra gasp out, eyes dilated and gaze hazy with lust. She still *loves* that, clearly.

"And you're beautiful," Adora coos to her , ducking to kiss the corner of her jaw as she tugs on her ear again. Catra whines and her legs shift, *almost* to where Adora needs them, though it isn't like she's going to slip in the strap without Catra giving her a clear okay, she just wants to get it in position so Catra can feel it. Catra' s next growl comes in the middle of a gasp for air, and Adora *knows* that sound. t might as well be her sex growl, worked up and desperate - done being toyed with and ready for more. She has to pause her kisses to grin against Catra's neck for a moment, but she only gets one more in before Catra decides that's enough.

She braces her elbows on the bed again and leans up, basically forcing Adora to pull her ear or let go, and Adora is not letting go, so Catra really just succeeds in making herself moan as she bites Adora's shoulder. Adora moans too as Catra buries her teeth in her. It's quiet, but it's kind of beautiful to hear her voice mixed with Catra's again. She tugs on Catra's ear a little firmer than she dared before, desperate to earn that sound again, and the moan she gets back is beautifully throaty. Catra shifts her hips, ready for more, and apparently decides she is going to lose this game of theirs soon.

Adora is pretty confident that's the only reason Catra would spread her legs for her so "easily" right now. She knows in a few moments Adora is going to have her too desperate to keep it up, so she chooses to make it all a decision that she made by herself – supposedly. It's a very Catra thing to do, and it has Adora chuckling as she tilts her head back and gives Catra better access to her neck. Catra releases that delicious growl again, sending shivers through Adora as she does her best to shift her hips into the correct position with her upper half trapped by Catra's teeth like this.

Adora has *ideas* and she needs to have her weight centered differently to fulfill them. She has just enough leverage from her braced armed to shift without having to let go of Catra's ear, giving it a few short tugs to keep the fire burning in Catra as she finally shifts so she can rest on her knees and properly work her hips. That isn't all she is planning, however. The strap is still just pressing against Catra, rubbing against her folds, but Catra isn't at the right angle for this. Finally able to push off her arm, Adora tugs on Catra's ear until it makes her gasp out enough for her to release Adora's shoulder so she can draw in air.

Her back arches in the process and Adora grins as she slips a hand beneath Catra. She shifts back, still leaned forward just enough that she can keep pulling Catra's ear when she wants – when *she* wants, not when Catra does, because she plans to give Catra a small taste of her own bratty medicine once she gets her going – but for now she focuses on pulling Catra up by the small of her back. It lines her

up so Adora can properly slide the strap against her while also letting her fingers find the base of her tail so she can rub it firmly.

Catra's cry out is small but *desperate* and her hips jolt down, sliding her against the strap. Her expression is pure lust, cheeks flushed with her eyes screwed up, but when Adora tugs on her ear again without giving her a moment to recover, her eyes fly open and reveal her pupils are dilated. Adora is a little breathless with excitement, flexing her hips just enough to get the strap coated in her wetness. Catra is fisting the sheets now.

"You want more, brat?" Adora asks, her voice as smug as it is fond. She calls Catra a brat mostly to acknowledge her efforts. Catra didn't just *roll over for her* and they both know it. It's up to her if Adora has earned this yet. Catra tries to glare, and while her eyes are narrowed enough for it as she looks down her own body at Adora, the flush on her face and way her hair is starting to muss kind of ruins the effect.

"Get *on* with it, I don't have all night," she snaps. Adora chuckles as she presses up on Catra's back just to get her in a better position, though the way it makes her gasp is certainly a *benefit*. Apparently they've gone from Catra making her work for her to it being Adora's fault that they're not already fucking.

"Sorry, I don't know what I was thinking taking so long," Adora says, conversationally, grinning as she finally presses in. Even worked up, it takes a second for Catra's body to give beneath her. Her last few words are lost in Catra's loud gasp as she throws her head back and rolls her hips down. Once Adora is past her entrance, she takes the strap *easily*, sinking all the way down on it. Catra's weight settling down on her hips again feels *incredible* and Adora pants for herself as she holds there for a long moment. She works her fingers against the base of Catra's tail and grins, turned on and *happy*, as it makes Catra roll her hips on the strap.

"*Adora*," Catra growls out, slitting her eyes open to glare down at her. Adora hums, pulling on her ear and watching Catra's displeased look immediately disappear as her eyes flutter shut. Catra *can* get off on

just the base of her tail being rubbed and her ears being pulled, but right now she doesn't want to. Adora doesn't want to get her off with just that either , but she's making Catra wait for it the same way that she did to her.

She won't last as long as Catra, though. Adora combines a hard rub at her tail with another ear tug and feels her mouth go dry at the whine Catra releases, shifting desperately in the sheets. Adora needs this *forever*, which means she needs to pick up the pace before Catra can start adjusting and the desperation fades. She gives a small pulse of her hips, not much movement but still *enough* because Catra gasps and her hands fly up from the sheets so she can wrap her arms around Adora's back. This time when her claws dig in, it isn't to be a brat, but to cling on. Whether it's from desperation or a necessity given the way Adora is forcing her lower back up, she doesn't know, but she hopes it's at least partially the former.

"So pretty when you're whining," Adora murmurs to her as she stutters her hips in time with another ear pull. Catra, in the middle of giving her one of those delicious whines, warps it into a growl by the end.

"Fuck, shut *up*, Adora," Catra tries to snap back, but her voice is totally desperate and her claws are digging in deeper as Adora rubs against her tail again. Adora grins as she stutters her hips and feels the vibration Catra makes when she tries to silence her reaction. Whether it was going to be a purr or a growl, Adora doesn't know and she *really* wishes she did, but she'll take that rumble as it is. She wants to totally overwhelm Catra with how good she feels and she's not quite there yet, but she isn't far .

Adora knows the rhythm Catra needs. She knows when to stutter her hips in time with a rub on her tail and to delay the pull on her ear until the moment after she releases the pressure her tail, right when Catra *thinks* she's going to get relief. She earns moaning and Catra's tail stiffening in return. Adora is gasping as surely as Catra is as she stutters her hips, the air hot and heavy from their breaths and her

body burning again. Catra's skin is hot against her, her moans filling the air and the scent of sex surrounding them. t' s only going to get more intense, but Adora is determined to get Catra off like this first.

t feels like they've been worked up for an hour and Adora has already gotten off for herself. She doesn't know how Catra has held on this long, but she starts letting out whines intermixed with growls and that's how Adora *knows*. She makes her movements with the strap a little harsher, more erratic and harder for Catra to predict, and she ups her movements against the base of Catra's tail. One last hard tug on her ear and Catra's claws are raking up her back as she arches and throws her head back. Adora's moans join Catra' s as she leans forward to bury her face in her neck and feel every one of those gasps against her skin.

She holds the strap buried in Catra as her orgasm rocks through her, releasing her ear but keeping her hand on Catra's back to hold her in place, though she uses the flat of her hand now to keep from overstimulating her too much. Catra's claws also release her back and her arms fall away, but Adora is pretty sure that's just because she is going limp. When Catra's gasps slow down, the purr Adora has been looking forward to this whole time rumbles to life. Adora lets out a slow breath as some of the tension leaks out of her and she breathes in Catra. She's still worked up, but that vibration does a lot of things for her and chief amongst them is soothing her.

Working her up in a *good* way is the next in line, giving her an outlet for her energy. She nuzzles against Catra' s neck and breathes her in until Catra starts shifting again. t only takes seconds, really , because they're both way too worked up for *one* to be enough. Adora kisses her neck, a silent assurance she isn't going to make her wait long, as she rubs gently at the base of Catra's ear. t' s to soothe her as much as it is to *thank* her for letting Adora toy with her using it for so long. She doesn't know if Catra will get that entire message, but if she says it out loud she's pretty sure Catra is going to turn on the brat again, so she leaves it at a touch.

As her kisses reach the join of Catra's neck and shoulder, Adora's hand finally leaves her ear and makes it way down to Catra's hips. She wants to fuck her *badly*, and she wants to get a better view of it too, which means abandoning her ear so she can lean back and work. She thinks she has pushed Catra to the limits of how much she can enjoy that before it gets painful or annoying, anyway. She has a hand free to help brace them now, which means she can hold Catra's hips in place and fuck her properly now. Her hand isn't going to leave her tail, though. The strap is to drive her wild, but the tail touches are to actually push her over.

She kisses her way down Catra's chest as she shifts back, not wanting to pull away all at once and leave Catra exposed and cold. Okay, Adora is actually on *fire* and she's sure Catra is too regardless of her orgasm, but the point stands. Catra gets pretty damn cuddly and needy post-orgasm, but she's worked up enough that Adora doesn't think they've hit that phase yet. She notices Catra's hands are kneading the sheets, though, so maybe.

Catra slits her eyes open and looks down at Adora as she nips lightly at the bottom of her breast. Adora smiles at her with her eyes, because right now her mouth is a little occupied latching onto Catra's nipple, careful and light so she doesn't hurt her where she's a little *too* sensitive. Catra's pupils dilate and her eyelids flutter, but she holds Adora's gaze as a fire rekindles behind her eyes. Yeah, the post-orgasm haze was brief, but that just means Adora gets to bring her over again.

This time, she can lean back and hold Catra in place, rocking the strap into her hard and watching her squirm. Maybe Catra can sense her thoughts, or maybe she's just ready again, because her eyes flare.

"Get to work," she orders. Adora releases her nipple with a grin and sits back, pulling Catra's hips up into position and luxuriating in the slight gasp that earns.

She will *happily*.

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Adora *loves* rocking into Catra fast and hard, trapping her hips with her hands so she can watch the rest of her writhe to compensate as she moans, whines, and cries out, so spent that growls have long since been abandoned. She loves when Catra is in the mood for it like this, tiring Adora out as much as Adora overworks her until she goes limp on her third orgasm and doesn't immediately start shifting again.

Adora gets off barely having to touch herself at all. She tries to awkwardly slip her hand beneath the strap before she realizes that isn't going to happen right now, so she slips the strap out of Catra carefully. Catra is hazy enough to whine at the loss, unashamed and needy, but Adora is sure she must be approaching overworked anyway and couldn't be fucked like that again. Adora pulls the harness off quickly. She comes after only a few moments of touching herself while watching Catra stretched out in her bed, shivering and boneless post-orgasm. The small whines on her breath are really all Adora needs to get there. She's trembling herself between physical exhaustion and stringing her own desire out fucking Catra.

It's *incredible*, but she has pushed that position to its limits. She's also partially motivated by the desire to keep things exciting for Catra—and to get to hold her. Catra purrs when Adora gently pushes her shoulder to turn her onto her side so she can lay beside her. With her chest pressed to Catra's back, she wraps around her, molding their bodies together. It's hot and sweaty, but getting to bury her face in Catra's hair and kiss her neck is worth it. It's nice to just lay behind her and feel her purr as she waits for Catra to start stirring again.

She *knows* they're not done, but she doesn't want to overwork Catra, especially not too soon, so she slowly pets down Catra's stomach and cards her fingers through the soft thatch of fur just above where

she hasn't actually gotten to touch yet and *really* wants to. She slips her fingers down to trace through her folds first, giving her a little stimulation to start perking her up before she finally touches around Catra's clit, though she still doesn't do it directly.

Catra is still purring in the post-orgasm haze. Adora nuzzles against her as she gently plays with her, busying herself with kisses down Catra's neck. Her cheek brushes against the scar there and she pulls her head back to look at it even as she absently scissors her fingers on either side of Catra's clit. Catra lets out a small, displeased sound and Adora freezes her hand until she realizes Catra is shifting her hips forward.

Oh, she needs more. Adora smiles to herself as she sets to more direct touches, still keeping the pressure gentle so she can steadily ramp it up as Catra comes out of it until she finds herself right back *in* it. She presses a soft kiss beside the scar before she tucks her face back into Catra's neck. She wanted to get a better look at the scar now that Catra is distracted, but it's clearly healing over and this moment is now more important than the memory of her fear when she first found the old wound back on the street.

She has had Catra stretched out beneath her enough tonight to know she doesn't have anything else worrying on her. She was mostly writhing, but Adora was dragging her eyes over every inch of her and she's sure she would have noticed something wrong even if her focus at the time was on how fucking hot Catra looked. Still, she curls her one free hand up to cup Catra's jaw, unable to position it much better when Catra is laying on top of her forearm. It works out. It feels really intimate to rest her hand there and cradle not only her body, but her face too.

"You want more?" Adora breathes into Catra's neck, because she thinks she might be ready and she would really like to get to feel Catra writhing against her this time, all her little growls and moans echoing in Adora's own chest. Catra draws in a breath and holds it, shifting her hips back and forth either to grind onto Adora's hand or to feel out how she feels about the stimulation. Probably both.

"Yeah, just don't be a prick about it and go too rough," Catra returns despite how she was yelling *harder* five minutes ago. Even three orgasms in she has to be a *little* bit of a brat, but it has Adora smiling as she readjusts her hand to touch her directly. Catra doesn't quite gasp, but her breathing gets heavy. Adora was desperate to fuck her earlier, but now she has had her like that, it feels amazing to get to touch her instead, fingertips wet as they slide over her and work her up again.

Catra sighs and sinks down into the touch like it's *soothing*. She melts in Adora's arms, letting her touch at her own pace, building up the pressure slowly. If she tried this for round one, she is sure Catra would have been an utter brat about it and she would have barely been able to keep her hands on her, but now she has Catra purring and sweet for her. It's because of the strap, really, burning off Catra's energy and satisfying her until she's content enough to just let Adora love her. She has burned off Catra's energy like this when she is just short of aggravation before, but it has never been as conditional as it is now.

She loves Catra writhing for her, but she might love Catra relaxed and boneless more. She loves the small gasps and tiny whines Catra gives as it gets to be too much and Adora is forced to hold her hand still for a few moments, letting Catra feel the pressure but keeping it undemanding until she has relaxed enough for Adora to start pushing her towards the edge again. She has missed Catra like this. She's gasping along with Catra – though not as heavily – as Catra's sounds turn into stuttery purrs in between gasps, her legs and tail shifting weakly.

She needs more – or at least thinks she does – because she lets out sharp, annoyed huffs when Adora doesn't speed up her touch to get her off faster. Whatever Catra *wants*, Adora is pretty sure she couldn't take it. Catra gives up on rushing her after a harsh bite to Adora's hand succeeds in nothing but turning Adora on. Catra stays growly and squirmy, though. Adora ups the speed of her hand. She

wants to keep things good for Catra. While worked up feels amazing, she doesn't want to string her out now.

She wants this steady and soft. Despite Catra's noises of "displeasure," it still is. Catra just gets noisy when she's about to come. Growls turn to purrs and moans and then she's gasping out, her tail thumping hard against Adora's shins and all of her stiffening. Adora holds her hand steady, holding her through it as Catra arches and then goes limp. Even her post-orgasm purr is limp, a shiver running through her back and into Adora that doesn't quite make it to audible. Adora loves it regardless, absently wiping her hand off in the sheets before she wraps both arms around Catra, even hiking one leg over hers so she can totally surround her.

Catra kneads, slowly and absently, at the bed. She nuzzles a little back into Adora before going utterly limp. She's not unconscious or anything, but it feels like she just *drops* with no chance of stirring – aside from the occasional flex of her hands, that is. Adora feels a deep contentment settle in her own bones, no orgasm required, as she cradles the girl that she loves close, no hint of animosity in the air. She can tell the afterglow is going to linger this time. She'll get to luxuriate in having Catra like this for a while, the best kind of exhaustion pulling her body into the sheets and helping her forget how crushing it is going to be when Catra recovers and starts pulling back on her clothes to leave.

It takes a long time for Catra to stir – so long that Adora stops occasionally humming along with Catra's purrs or intermittently nuzzling into her hair, just lying limp against her, happy for every moment she that gets.

It takes so long, she doesn't notice the satisfied exhaustion turning into sleep pulling at her limbs, or when she slips away into blackness with Catra still in her arms.

Chapter End Notes

Tank tops (especially muscle tanks) and sports bras are like, the height of slutty butch fashion.
(Also Iwant it noted Ifind “emotion support [plank]” jokes annoying as they trivialize something legitimately important and helpful for some people, but it’s okay when Ido it because I have an ESA LMAO)

"Meaningless" Morning Afters

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wasn't expecting to wake up with Catra. She didn't even realize they were falling asleep together, just trying to relax and enjoy having Catra close while it lasted. It was late and she had burned off all her energy, but she was sure Catra leaving would wake her up. She didn't dare entertain the idea of Catra staying. She absolutely *wanted* it, but she assumed that it would imply too much emotion for Catra, even if it is something Adora does even with unknown one night stands

Catra didn't leave. She is nestled face down in the bed beside her, pinning Adora's arm underneath her and seemingly boneless. Adora can tell she is awake even if she has her eyes closed, and she's sure Catra can tell that *she* is too, but both of them just keep laying there, pretending they aren't so they can keep cuddling as long as possible. At least, that's why Adora is doing it. Catra might just not want to face her now the afterglow has faded and she has realized that she let herself fall asleep here.

Experimentally, Adora shifts, hoping to roll onto her side so she can hold Catra, but Catra lets out a small, displeased growl and Adora freezes in place. Lying still seems to appease her. Catra returns to lying docile in her arms, not as melted as she was before, but still relaxed and now quiet again. Adora tries to tilt her head just enough to get a look at her, but without turning her head and maybe even changing position, all she can see is the spiky top of Catra's newly-short hair. Adora kind of wants to bury her hands in it.

She doesn't want to risk scaring Catra off, but Catra is still in her bed, so after several moments of her not showing a sign of moving – even though she's all but admitted to being awake with her growl –

Adora purposefully turns her head and curls a bit more around Catra. Catra starts to growl and tense as she shifts, but her grumbling tapers off after Adora wraps her arms around her, her face now buried in Catra's short hair. She waits to see if Catra is going to turn away, but after a few moments Catra relaxes again.

There's a wariness to how she lays in Adora's arms now, but she's *still here*. Is it just too early for her to get up? Catra has always slept in. To be honest, Adora still considers it a win that even half asleep Catra is allowing her to cuddle. She would prefer for Catra to stay for breakfast if she can convince her to, though. Adora doesn't want to chase her away by asking too much, but she also doesn't want to waste whatever moments she has with Catra. She knows they're going to be limited. She needs to enjoy what she can.

She turns her head, nuzzling into Catra's hair and then pressing a kiss to her ear. Shockingly, Catra doesn't growl at her. Her ear twitches a little, but Adora knows from experience that they just do that sometimes when touched. She nudges to a better position and kisses it again. This time Catra doesn't try to twitch it away. Adora can't be *stopped* now, kissing Catra's ear probably a dozen times before Catra finally speaks.

"Knock it off. I know you don't treat your other hook-ups like this," she mumbles. She doesn't sound upset. She also doesn't sound tired. She hasn't been allowing this just because of exhaustion, then. Adora pauses, still nuzzled into her hair.

"Sometimes I do, actually," she corrects. Catra *snarls*, still not emerging from the pillow. She clearly hates that, but when the snarl ends, she doesn't move away despite her tail lashing behind her. Shortly after word of Adora's hook-ups made its way back to Catra via Entrapta – hook-ups which at that point were three make outs and only one actual night with someone else – Adora pointed out that she would never even think about someone else if Catra took her back, but she had to fill the void somehow. It didn't seem to help, but then again they *did* make out a few moments later, so maybe it left an impact. It impacted Adora, at least. She stopped for a few

weeks, hoping that Catra would come back around and wanting as few complications between them as possible.

Instead, she found out that Catra had started up with Scorpia.

"Hey , morning sex is fun," Adora tries, hoping to convey – without saying it clearly enough for Catra to run – that when she does this with other people, that's all it is about. Nothing she does with Catra is *just* anything, regardless of what Catra might claim. Whenever she does something like this with a hook-up, it's as lead up to a make out or more. She just wants to cuddle Catra as much as possible right now, though she isn't opposed to more.

"Are you planning to follow through?" Catra asks. Her tone is halfway between a mumble – though the pillow is helping with that effect – and a dry comment. Suddenly Catra lingering makes sense. *Round two* – or like, six, whatever they're on – could be both an incentive and an excuse. Adora really hopes it's just an excuse. She hums as she shifts to run a hand up and down Catra's back, feeling her out. Unlike *Adora's* back, Catra doesn't have any nail marks dragging down her skin from last night. She might not have any marks at all. Adora wants to fix that, leaving reminders all over her of what it feels like to be with her, but she also wants to treat Catra softly. She probably won't have to choose, though. They both like cuddly morning sex, but she doubts that Catra is going to allow that today.

"If you're awake enough," Adora promises, nipping playfully at Catra's ear. She doesn't really tug on it – between pulling on them so much yesterday and not having great control with her teeth, she doesn't want to risk hurting her – but Catra still lets out the cutest little trill in response. Catra shifts and for a moment Adora thinks that she's trying to pull away, but then she realizes she's just tucking her ears back and hiding her face in the pillow. It could be embarrassment or, despite clearly enjoying it, it could be a signal not to mess with her ears right now.

Adora does mess with them more, but only to nuzzle in and press a few kisses at the super soft fur on the back of her ear. It's easier to

kiss without getting hair in her mouth now. Or rather, she probably gets the same amount in her mouth, but it's short and still connected to Catra's head, so she doesn't have to pull a long strand off her tongue in the middle of an otherwise fun make out session. She slides her hand up Catra's back, burying it in her hair and ruffling it a little. Catra huffs into the pillow she's trying to hide in, but she still doesn't pull away.

"You know, you can only act so annoyed while staying before I start suspecting that you *might* like me," Adora teases, drawing out the *might* and giggling a little on the *me* when Catra immediately makes an offended noise. It shouldn't be a lighthearted joke given the year of loneliness between them, but they've always made jokes like this and, despite the breakup, Adora has never stopped believing Catra cared about her. Maybe not liked her, but she wasn't going to just stop caring immediately even if she did say that she hated her.

(Catra says a lot of things she doesn't mean. It makes it hard to spot the truths.)

"I like how you fuck, so I'd get on that before it's too late," Catra replies, voice huffy, but it's still nothing like the vitriol she spit at Adora a few months ago, or even as harsh as some of the things she said to her last night. She barely even turns her mouth out of the pillow to say it, doing everything in her power to keep her face tucked in and eyes covered, because if she can't see Adora's grin, apparently it doesn't exist.

Or it's something else. Or she's hiding her cheeks, because Catra can get *blushy* when she's flustered – but that's definitely wishful thinking, because Adora hasn't done anything to earn that. Adora hums, scratching lightly at Catra's scalp before she slides her hand down and returns to running it over her, just enjoying touching Catra. Last night she knew she was on a timer, only allowed so much leniency to touch, kiss, or admire before Catra would get frustrated and demand they hurry up. Now she hopes Catra will let her take her time, but instead Catra huffs again, unsatisfied with her pace.

"Impatient kitty," Adora teases, smiling as she presses a kiss against the base of Catra's ear. It's another thing she wouldn't have *dared* saying last night when Catra was in the mood to fight her, but though it is the final straw this morning as well, Catra doesn't leave. No, she gives a cute little growl of frustration and pushes herself up off the mattress, crawling over Adora and forcing her to roll onto her back so Catra can climb on top. Adora grins at her as Catra glares – adorably, with flushing cheeks – down at her.

"Thought you would know better than to taunt a cat by now," Catra bites back, leaning down and kissing Adora – to shut her up, probably, but really it's only positive reinforcement. It's kind of hard to kiss around a smile, but after a moment Adora manages to tamp it down so she can kiss Catra back. The kiss is hot, both their mouths open the moment Adora pulls herself together. It's not filthy, but it lights Adora's blood on fire. Maybe she's just too much of a fuckboy at this point to have normal standards, but the feeling of connection she gets from the kiss gives her a rush.

It's Catra in her purest form – passionate, needy, and affectionate, wrapped in this façade of sinful intentions that are far from fake, but not all there is to her either. Adora is projecting so much, but it feels like the exact kind of kiss they used to share when they were allowed to love each other, making out without a care in the world. The knowledge of a possible dirty conclusion would be there, but not necessarily guaranteed. A kiss like this could be enough. It's *them* and it comes so naturally that it means far too much for how simple it is.

Catra nudges a thigh between Adora's own and Adora buries both her hands in her hair. Catra can do what she wants with her body – or what she wants *on* her body, because now she's straddling Adora's thigh – as long as she doesn't stop kissing her like this. She doesn't know if this is just the closest that Catra is getting to a filthy kiss this early in the morning or if it's *instinct* to kiss Adora like this, but it feels like everything. Then again, maybe Catra isn't a freak like Adora and an open-mouthed kiss doesn't make her lose her mind.

Catra grinds down on her thigh and whimpers. Adora's mind goes *yes* for a half second before she registers the edge of pain to the sound. Catra pulls back from the kiss, lifting her hips in the process. Now they've parted, Adora can see her wincing.

"Never mind, I'm sore," Catra says, sounding as dejected as she is annoyed. Adora barely has the time to unthread her fingers from her hair before Catra flops down beside her. She lands on her side, her cheek squishing adorably against the pillow. She is pouting just enough to deny, but that denial would be a lie. Adora has never wanted to kiss her more in her life. Well, at least not since they got together. She spent most of high school pretending that it wasn't burning her up that she couldn't kiss Catra, hiding it from the world and herself.

She rolls over, reaching up and squishing Catra's face between her hands. Catra rolls her eyes and sighs.

"You're a baby," Catra says, her voice dry. Adora smiles, leaning down and pressing a kiss to Catra's cute little pout. Despite her protests, Catra tilts her head up into it without hesitation for the few seconds they connect. Adora could gladly make out all morning if that's what Catra wants, but she pulls back to send her a shit-eating grin.

"Aw, I thought you didn't like that pet name, but I'm happy with anything you want to call me, babe," Adora replies, smirking as Catra immediately pulls a face. It doesn't feel like she actually hates it – though it is true that she was never a fan of the endearment – but more like she's going along with the joke. Catra lays an arm over Adora with a haughty sniff, pulling her down from her half-propped up state.

"Shut up and be still," she grumbles, turning her head enough to wap an ear in Adora's face. Adora pauses, blinking at Catra as she closes her eyes and nuzzles down into the pillow again. Adora definitely isn't being quiet – she's giving Catra shit – but she *is* still,

the only movement in the bed Catra settling into place curled against her.

No, Adora is pretty sure Catra is asking her to cuddle her. Not *directly*, but she's Catra, so talking around what she wants is the norm. Lying together quietly amounts to cuddling right now. Catra isn't just allowing it, she's willing to imply that it's what she wants in the most roundabout way possible. Adora is sure if she pointed it out then Catra would claim that she's just trying to go back to sleep, but Catra wants to stay like this.

Adora kisses her ear again. She doesn't really have to move to do it, so she isn't disobeying Catra, and Catra doesn't complain about it either. Actually, her tail sweeps forward to curl over Adora's legs, a *come closer* beckon if Adora knows one. Adora nuzzles her hair as she shuffles them together so they're pressed together chest-to-chest now, not tight enough that Catra has to move to allow it since she seems comfortable on the pillow, but now they can cuddle more properly.

Catra shifts too. She doesn't open her eyes, but her hand finds Adora's hip and starts to knead. It hurts, but when Adora sucks in a sharp breath, it's from excitement, and maybe a bit of happiness too. She holds it, not wanting to release any pained sound and make Catra stop, not when Catra is comfortable enough to be kneading without the endorphins of an orgasm soothing her first. Catra snorts into the pillow.

"Breathing is kind of important, Adora," she comments without opening her eyes. Adora could easily disagree it isn't as important as this, but she huffs out a laugh and it's all a lost cause anyway. She tilts her head forward so she can rest her forehead against Catra's crown, closing her eyes and just enjoying the softness to her hair. It really is a better texture now that she has cut it. Adora might get some of it in her mouth if she tries to talk now, and Catra already told her not to anyway, but she does have something she should say.

"Sorry I made you sore. I should have been more careful," Adora says. She doesn't want to skate over that even if she couldn't resist poking before. Catra's ear flicks.

"Please," she scoffs, "I didn't want you to waste my time with gentle sex." Adora frowns to herself. Catra loves gentle sex, even if she prefers it hard or just casual more often. That's part of what makes the soft moments so beautiful. It's too overwhelming for Catra often, but it's incredible when they're both in the mood for it. Catra clearly wasn't in the mood for it last night, though, so she guesses that she has a point.

"How about," Adora proposes, drawing out her words as she shifts to cup Catra's jaw so she can tilt her face up and prepare to kiss her again, "you stay for breakfast? Maybe you'll feel up to more after it," she breathes out against Catra's lips. She feels Catra's breath hitch a little, but that's probably just from the proximity. Catra doesn't hesitate to tip her head up to seal their lips together, skipping answering, but *hopefully* just because she's thinking about it.

It's an unashamed excuse to have Catra stay, but it's one that Catra might not reject on principle. Adora adds a veil of seduction to it with the kiss just to give her some plausible deniability. Catra *did* stay the night just for another round after all, so what's another hour?

If they do have sex again, it will have to be a gentle touch with hands that can be careful, not toys or thighs that make it harder to feel every twitch and react to it. As eager as Adora is for an excuse to treat Catra softly, really she's just in it for the opportunity to have Catra in her kitchen and actually talk with her. Maybe. Somehow she has a feeling that Catra is going to get more closed off once they leave the bed. It seems likely that she's just too comfortable—and needy—to be pissy right now. The bed might as well be a liminal space where they could be broken up or it could be any one of the hundreds of mornings where they woke up with no timebomb ticking on their time together.

Catra's kiss is far too lazy for there to not be *some* kind of effect from the bed. It's sweet just like before, if less dirty, but that might just be because it's tinged by knowing that they aren't going to have sex soon. Catra kisses her like nothing happened between them for several long seconds before she goes limp in Adora's hands and Adora gently lowers her head back to the bed. Catra rumbles, her eyes still closed from the kiss as she settles in.

"Fine, but you better not burn it," Catra agrees, yawning as she rubs her cheek against the pillow. Adora grins as she watches Catra scent mark her pillow. As much as she doesn't want to fuck this up, she can't promise that. She's never had a more tempting distraction.

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Adora does her best to split her attention evenly between stealing glances at Catra and paying attention to what she's doing as she begins cooking. She's going all out, trying to give Catra the best breakfast she possibly can with her cooking skill – and to show off how much it has improved in the last year she was on her own – but half of her attention is the best that the skillet could possibly ask for when Catra is sitting on her counter wearing only a borrowed pair of running shorts. Adora isn't wearing much more, in just an oversized t-shirt that only covers her lack of underwear when she doesn't lift her arms but that at least protects her from any possible skillet sizzling.

"Entrapta is probably going to be back at the track soon," Catra comments, attention fixed on her phone. She has sent a few text messages since retrieving it from the pants that she didn't even pretend she was going to put on. She actually walked into the kitchen naked the first time and then went back to steal shorts when she took a glance around and seemingly decided the best place to

sit was on the counter. Despite being unsanitary, Adora would have let her perch there and just cleaned it afterwards.

"Really? I mean, that would be great, but I thought she wanted more challenge?" Adora asks, glancing at Catra's phone despite how she can't see her screen at all. Entrapta was a god when it came to building racers, but there are a lot of restrictions on the professional circuit that she chafed under. Catra grunts.

"She's getting bored bickering over Melog with me," Catra returns. Adora frowns. Catra has been possessive of Melog ever since she started pouring all the resources she had into building up her own bike that could compete with Swift Wind, but there were only two possible reasons for Catra to recruit Entrapta and Melog was the nice one.

"Didn't you poach her just to work on your bike?" Adora asks. It was either that or to mess with Adora, either from pettiness or in a deliberate act of sabotage. Bow is good, just like Catra is good, but no one is as good as Entrapta, so Swift Wind hasn't really seen any improvement since the last time Entrapta touched him. Between Bow's skill and Adora's knowledge of Catra's work, they can easily keep him in shape, but neither of them really knows how to push him further than he's already been pushed.

"She has a magic touch, but we have different ideas sometimes and I'm *territorial*. There's not enough work to entertain her, anyway," Catra returns, throwing Adora a smirk on *magic touch* that makes her narrow her eyes. Still, Entrapta coming back would be good for more than just Swift Wind. Catra recruited Entrapta to the chop shop without showing any concern for the life of crime she was leading her into. All she had to say to Entrapta was that she could build whatever she wanted without having to worry about the law, much less championship regulations, and Entrapta was gone in an instant.

"Besides, she'll keep helping me with Melog even if she comes back, so didn't get any ideas about her being yours again," Catra finishes, looking back to her screen. Adora has a *feeling* she doesn't like, but

she focuses on the food for a moment as she decides what to do with that information. She should reach out to Entrapta tonight to make it clear they'll take her back in an instant, but she needs to figure out what to say. When Entrapta left, she seemed nonplused by Adora's arguments against working for the Horde.

"Just thought she'd be having more fun at the shop. At least as long as no one tried to limit her there, too," Adora says, watching Catra in the corner of her eye. It's small talk, but she's also should know what isn't satisfying Entrapta so she can approach her right later. She certainly fucked it up before. Catra's tail flicks, the end thudding against Adora's cabinet.

"She's not at the shop anymore," she says. Adora stares. Catra does a valiant job of ignoring her, but her twitching tail gives away that she's aware of the impact of her statement. Melog not being enough work for Entrapta on its own makes perfect sense, but Entrapta managing to *breathe* without access to a shop doesn't, much less why she would leave when the idea of building unrestricted made her so giddy in the first place.

Catra sighs, putting her phone to sleep and finally looking up to make eye contact.

"Remember how I said it was time to go last night?" Catra says, only confusing Adora more, but she nods. Catra leans back on the counter, bracing herself on her hands and now conveniently looking up at the ceiling. "Two cops walked in. Out of uniform, but given the circumstances, I'm not taking the risk," she says. Adora is still staring.

"You love risk," she says. *Circumstances* is vague. The comment makes Catra smirk, and she actually flicks her gaze down to make eye contact with Adora for a moment.

"Only when it's fun," she returns, pushing off the counter and sitting up again. "They're looking for me after that deal where I got hurt. Not that they saw enough of me to know what they're looking for, but I'm

lying low with Scorpia and Entrapta right now to be safe,” she says. That makes sense to Adora – and also makes her want to bundle Catra away in her house until she’s safe to do what she wants again – but she has no idea how it relates to Entrapta coming back to the track.

“How did Entrapta get caught up in that?” Adora asks, furrowing her brow. Catra looks down to the side, and for a moment Adora thinks she is ignoring her, and then she realizes she’s looking at the stove. Adora turns, scrambling to turn the heat off and move the skillet to a cold burner. Nothing burned, but it was damn close. She doesn’t keep her attention there, though, turning and looking back at Catra as soon as there’s no risk of fire. Distraction gone, Catra reluctantly twists her mouth for a moment, expression settling into a scowl.

“The cops showing up to that sale made no sense, but Hordak has been trying to expand and is dealing with another gang or some shit. Shadow Weaver didn’t seem happy about it. I’m pretty sure she was selling us out to get Hordak arrested so she could take control herself. She tried to pin the whole thing on me when I got back, and then Hordak tried to convince Entrapta to stay without me. I was still bleeding out, too. It was a fucking disaster,” Catra goes from scowling to sucking in a breath and looking down at the floor, her shoulders hunched together. Adora moves to comfort her without thinking about it, her hands coming up to Catra’s shoulder to anchor her.

“I almost lost it all in like an hour. I might not have walked away from it if it weren’t for Scorpia. I wasn’t in the shape for another fight,” Catra admits, her voice steady but body language closed off. Adora’s heart hammers in her chest, a reflection of how she felt last night when she heard about the injury for the first time. She tries to pull Catra into a hug, but Catra stays rooted in her spot, resisting the pull and glaring down at the floor.

“I’m fine now that I don’t have a blade snapped off in my neck,” she snaps, fixing her glare on Adora. Adora presses her mouth into a line, but she reluctantly releases Catra. That seems to be enough for

the tension in Catra's shoulders to ease. At least she doesn't tell Adora to back away, too. She doesn't know that she could make herself do it. Catra returns to scowling over her shoulder.

"Anyway , seducing Entrapta didn't work out for Hordak for multiple reasons. Imanaged to convince her to stick with me once Igot back on my feet. Well, Iconvinced her to stick with *Melog* since the other racers' they gave her weren't shit in comparison, but if W eaver's going to play dirty then so am I," Catra finishes, rallying until her voice is filled with a believable confidence. Adora would fall for it if she hadn't seen her just a moment before.

She wants to ask if Catra is sure that she's alright because she *can't* be, but that's only going to get her more scowling. She settles for dropping a hand to Catra's thigh and gently massaging it. Catra raises a brow, glancing down at it, but she doesn't pull away or even comment. Adora can't believe that Catra just isn't with the Horde anymore, but it sounds like it would have been impossible for her to stay. She must have walked. Adora is *bursting* with questions about that. It takes her several moments to find one that she can risk asking.

"What have you been up to the last few weeks, then?" she settles on. This must have been a while ago for Catra's neck to be healing over. Being distanced from the toxicity of the Horde since "betraying" it might explain why she's willing to be around Adora again, even if it's just to have sex, but clearly it didn't send Catra running straight back to her. Catra sniffs, narrowing her eyes at Adora for several long moments before deigning to answer the question.

"Racing. Y ou know Ive always been damn good even without Swift Wind. The bet money is enough for now. Scorpia has already found work at a regular mechanic shop, but Im holding onto my dreams of revenge for a bit longer. We're driving each other crazy couped up in Entrapta's apartment, though. There's a reason Ineeded stress relief bad enough to put up with you," Catra claims. Adora should probably be disheartened by that, but instead all she hears is that Catra needs her.

Adora steps closer, using her hand on Catra's thigh to nudge her legs apart. Catra tilts her head back and to the side, a motion Adora recognizes. She used to do it to get her hair out of her face, but now there's no hair to flip. She's just watching Adora. It's an invitation even if Catra looks wary. Adora settles between Catra's legs, Catra's knees framing her hips as they press against the counter, as close as they can get right now.

She still has so many questions – is Catra blacklisted from the Horde, along with Scorpia? Did Scorpia rescuing her change their relationship? Has she been barely keeping Entrapta busy with just the wear on her bike from races? Is she done with all the shit that tore them apart, and if she is, does that even mean she's willing to talk about it now? – but instead of asking any of them, she kisses Catra. That's what Catra is here for, supposedly. Catra kisses back, though it takes a several seconds before the tension starts to leak out of her.

Slowly, she lets her guard down, letting Adora kiss the stress of the last few minutes of conversation – and memories – away. If this is what she's coming to Adora for, then Adora can *do* this, and maybe Catra will remember how well Adora takes care of her and how happy she is to do it. She couldn't give Catra what she wanted when the Horde came between them, but she can give her this. She can *be* this for her. It's better than the nothing they have been for the last year.

The kiss ends when Adora tilts her head forward, keeping them close but angling her mouth away so they can both breathe. Catra stays there too, their foreheads resting together and their breathing the only sound for several long seconds. Adora hears it as loud as her drums usually are, a reminder puffing against her face to be grateful for Catra's continuous, spiteful will to survive. She isn't surprised Weaver chose Catra as her fall guy, but she is impressed by Catra's ability to come out of it with everything – everyone – she needs still intact.

"My bed is always open," Adora promises her. She leaves off the *for you* part. It would be the exact kind of emotion she was just helping Catra forget about. As much as she feels it, it isn't what Catra wants her to be right now, and following along with what she needs might – just maybe – eventually get them back to where Adora desperately wants them again. Catra lets out a sharp huff, but they're too close for Adora to tell if she's scowling even when she opens her eyes.

"I've noticed," Catra returns, her tone dry. At least she doesn't sound outright pissed like she did the last time they addressed *this* topic. Adora really wasn't trying to bring it up. She runs her hands down Catra's thighs and then up her body, trying to feel if the tension is back already. Catra certainly doesn't seem happy, but at least she isn't as unhappy as she was when talking about Shadow Weaver betraying her.

That's not a very high bar.

"I told you they're all meaningless to me. It's just something to feel less alone," Adora offers, voice quiet. She wants to assure Catra without getting deeper in this conversation and upsetting her again. Catra scoffs, but it's small without much energy behind it. That gives Adora some hope, but then Catra pulls back. Not far, she doesn't even pull away from Adora's hands now settled high on her waist, but she leans back to narrow her eyes at her.

"Sure. Did you bottom for any of them?" she asks, her tone sarcastic and almost testing. Adora blinks at her, wrinkling her brow after a moment when clarity doesn't come to her. Catra has been surprising her more often than usual with this conversation.

"No," she replies after a moment. She isn't sure what that proves. She isn't a hard top or anything, it's just her preference. Maybe Catra knows it's significance better than she does, though, because Adora is realizing now that she really had no interest in switching with the girls that she brought home. They had a moment of connection, she felt useful, and then they parted in the morning light after some small talk over pancakes.

"*Good*," Catra intones with a smile that is all teeth. Adora finds herself inexplicably blushing. That's possessive, and possessive probably means this is going to be a *problem*, but it also means that Catra wants Adora to be hers still, at least in some way. Adora isn't sure if – actually , *how much* – this is going to be a problem between them. She reaches up, brushing the curl of Catra's bangs out of her face in a silent gesture. She thinks actions might be more successful in getting Catra to open up than any verbal request could be. Clearly they need to talk about this at least a little. Catra sighs, clearly picking up on her intentions, but after a moment she locks gazes with her.

"Listen, you weren't alone in that. I've been hooking up with Scorpia and Entrapta too," she admits reluctantly . Of all the things that Adora was worried she would say, none of them were *that*. Adora feels her jaw drop.

"Entrapta? Wait- Both?" she asks, a lot of things from this conversation suddenly falling into place. She knew about Scorpia for probably as long as it has been happening, but Entrapta is a curveball. Catra rolls her eyes, a smile twitching at her lips.

"Not both at once," she corrects, which is only marginally less brain-breaking. An almost coy smile plays at Catra's lips. "And yes, Entrapta. Girl has the *good* toys. They're fancy. Some of them have names," Catra informs her . Adora's face feels red. For some reason she isn't nearly as jealous of Entrapta as she has been of Scorpia, but Entrapta never seemed like she could be replacing her. She also didn't seem like the kind to have a fancy sex toy collection, at least to Adora. She doesn't know what to do with that information except try not to picture them being used on Catra, no Entrapta involvement required.

"And yet you still missed our thirty dollar strap," Adora manages to smirk. Okay, she's definitely picturing those toys being used on Catra and wishing that she could take her back to the bedroom right now to show her that she can do everything Entrapta *and* Scorpia did for her, but at least she's managing to hold conversation. Catra laughs –

against her will, if the expression she makes afterwards is any indication.

"My expensive tastes are mostly limited to motorcycles and food. Besides, it's about the way you fuck," Catra returns, going for haughty but missing when she has a sparkle of laughter in her eyes still. Adora smiles, wrapping her arms around Catra's lower back and pulling her forward to the edge of the counter, so her hips can meet Adora's – without too much pressure, in case she's too sore for that.

"Aw, you missed *me*," Adora teases, actually a little giddy at the thought. That might not have been the takeaway Catra intended her to have, but after finding out she has even more to live up to than she thought, she's proud of what she can give Catra and eager to show it to her. Catra turns her face away, her cheeks flushing. She arches her back so her hips can stay against Adora even as she tries to hide her face. She raises a hand and covers Adora face with it, pushing Adora away from her. Adora grins as she turns her face with the movement, absorbing the momentum and keeping her arms locked around Catra.

"Don't get an even bigger head, your forehead eclipses enough already," Catra tells her, her voice obviously flustered even with her attempts to hide her face from Adora. Adora licks Catra's hand in retaliation. "Ew!" Catra immediately yanks her hand away, letting Adora see her flush again. Adora can feel herself grinning as she holds Catra close, cuddling her a little while Catra huffs.

"Go back to cooking, idiot. You promised me food," Catra grumbles, her tail lashing back and forth, but Adora can tell it's not from irritation. Catra definitely just doesn't want to acknowledge that Adora has flustered her, but Adora lets it go despite how much she wants to keep cuddling and pestering Catra on the counter. Maybe it's because Catra opened up to her a little bit, maybe it's because of what she said when she did, or maybe it's just because of Catra complimenting her skills in bed, but Adora feels a lot better than she did last night.

She was sure Catra was going to leave her at the first opportunity. She was already anticipating crying this morning. For the first time since Catra appeared on the dance floor, Adora isn't constantly plagued by the thought that every moment could be their last together. Sure, Catra is still being cagey, but she has *always* been cagey. Maybe Catra not being in the Horde anymore has given Adora too much hope and that won't change Catra's mindset as much as it changed hers, but having hope at all feels like a drug after the last year.

Okay, really she's just way too happy from poking around with Catra and that is enough to make her giddy like this on its own, but she turns back to the stove with a grin. She will need to put in extra work to make breakfast good after stopping halfway through, but she still plans to follow through. She has the music of Catra's flustered tail beating against the cabinets to accompany her as she works. It's enough to tide her over no matter how badly she wants to take that tail in her hand and pull it.

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Catra tries to hide in her phone as Adora returns to cooking, but every time Adora turns she throws Catra a grin – or a soft smile, or a flustered blush because she is stricken by the sight of Catra – and eventually Catra seems to decide that she can't put up with it anymore. Or maybe she can't hide how it's making her react too and wants to leave to "regain composure." The next time Adora smiles at her, she huffs and hops off the counter.

"Where are you going?" Adora asks, watching Catra walk towards the hallway. She pauses just within the doorway, looking back over her shoulder to send Adora a smirk.

"To put on clothes," she says. Adora's expression of horror is exaggerated, but not fabricated. Catra laughs, the sound echoing off the walls as she heads down the hall and out of sight. Adora can do nothing except finish their breakfast – which is nearly done anyway – but it feels like a bad sign that Catra wants to be dressed. Dressed probably means leaving. She certainly hasn't been bothered by sitting topless on the counter until now. She smirked whenever she caught Adora blushing at the sight of her.

Catra is gone for long enough that Adora finishes cooking their breakfast before she gets back. Catra isn't actually gone that long – it's like, three minutes – but there's no reason for Catra to be in the garage for that long. Because yeah, she went out to the garage, which confuses Adora for at least two of the three minutes until she finally remembers their jackets are out there. As Adora gets plates out for them, the thought of Catra getting her jacket makes her heart fall. That's definitely a *leaving* thing.

Then Catra walks back in.

She's wearing her leather jacket. And Adora's shorts. And nothing else. Adora fumbles with the plates, blushing as Catra immediately smirks at her. Apparently Catra's definition of *dressed* is just having her nipples covered. The jacket isn't even zipped, not that Adora wants it to be. Adora might feel more flustered than she did when Catra was completely naked. Maybe she was just getting used to that, but it somehow feels more illicit for her to be only partially covered. Catra saunters over to her, opening her mouth to no doubt call Adora an idiot, but Adora doesn't give her the chance, setting the luckily-still-empty plates aside and instead reaching for Catra.

Catra laughs once as Adora's hands find her waist, slipping just beneath the edge of her cropped jacket so she can pull her close and back her up against the counter. Catra does that "hair flip" again, throwing Adora a smile with a fang peeking out as she exposes her neck for Adora. Adora presses their bodies together, ducking to kiss down the length of Catra's neck. Now Catra has "clothes" on Adora immediately wants to take them off her again. Catra sneaks one

hand beneath the hem of her shirt – not that it's hard given its length – and squeezes her ass.

"You think you're so smooth, but you're so *easy*," Catra grins at her. Adora didn't need Catra to tell her that she was being baited. She also doesn't care, running her hands over her and gripping her hips so she can push Catra back against the counter just enough to pull them together again with *momentum* and getting a hitch from Catra's breath.

"I'm not the one posturing to be seductive right now," Adora points out. Catra scoffs above her, digging her claws in to the flesh of her ass and sending a shiver through Adora.

"As if you don't have practiced moves. I saw how you hung your jacket on Swift Wind. I bet you do that every time," she comments. Despite the subject matter, her tone is more dry than annoyed. It's not a tone Adora wants Catra to have when she's running her hands over her and kissing her neck – ideally Catra would be too lost in the touch to be sarcastic – but sometimes they talk to each other like this when they're two fingers deep, so it's closer to being the norm for them than a sign that Adora is losing her touch.

"That's not Swift Wind," Adora comments absently, latching on just above Catra's collarbone and setting to making a mark there to match the ones on her own back. Catra releases a displeased grunt and Adora freezes, but that only makes Catra scoff. She buries a hand in Adora's hair and encourages her back to her neck. It's not the kiss then, but her words. Adora gives up on the hickey, mostly because she's frowning now. She lifts her head, ignoring Catra's attempt to pull her back to her neck.

"It's not. Swift Wind is the one you built. My racing bike," Adora corrects, watching Catra scowl. Her tail thuds against the cabinets, trapped behind their legs. Catra pointedly yanks on her hair.

"Go back to kissing. It's the only way to guarantee you don't say something stupid," Catra orders her. Adora sighs, but she ducks to

press a soft kiss to Catra's neck.

"It's true," she murmurs as she makes her way back to the spot she was marking. She isn't sure about continuing now, but Catra is encouraging her to even if she's annoyed.

"There *isn't* a Swift Wind anymore, then. You turned it to scrap," Catra grumbles. Okay, Adora's definitely stopping now. She pulls away and this time Catra doesn't try to stop her. She drops her hands from her, doing her best to cross them over her chest with their hips still slotted together, only leaned back from each other at the waist. As much as this is *not* casual make out banter, Catra was furious and yelling the last time they touched on this subject, so this is honestly progress.

"Your work was moved to the new Swift Wind. Entrapta had to cuff it to make it fit within league specifications, but I didn't throw away what you built me. I used it how I was allowed to," Adora says, her brow furrowed. Catra immediately scoffs, turning her face away, but she doesn't push Adora off her or anything. They're kind of in a compromising position and Catra has shoved at her when discussing this in the past. Experimentally, Adora runs a hand over her side. Catra doesn't tense – she *isn't* tense, at least not all that much, which Adora is only realizing now.

"I told you it deserves to be out on the track, and it never could be on that frame," Adora tries, settling her hands on Catra's hips and squeezing. She at least *tried* to tell Catra that when they had their fight back at the track, but things got kind of blurry and she isn't sure what ended up being said, or *heard*. Catra *hmphs*, but she's pouting more than scowling now.

"You can say that. Won't change that it wasn't enough," Catra grumbles. Adora stares at her. She's pretty sure her mouth has fallen open. Catra valiantly doesn't look at her, only flicking an ear in her direction in response to whatever aghast look is on Adora's face.

This isn't the same Catra who yelled at her a few months ago, and Adora has to hope that's enough as she lifts her hands and frames Catra's face with them, turning her so she has to look her in the eye as Adora's gaze bores into her.

"Catra, I still think you're a god with a wrench, and in bed while I'm at it. I wanted to leave the Horde, not you. How many times do I have to say that before you believe me?" Adora says. Catra hisses, but she looks more flustered than angry. Her cheeks are red as she tries to glare somewhere around Adora's ear, not meeting her eyes. She can try to dodge her gaze away, but she has to see Adora still holding her gaze in her periphery no matter what. Adora is trying and she can't pretend she doesn't see it.

"I'll try a hundred more times and maybe it will start to make sense," Catra says, her tone sharp, but her tone can be fucking anything it wants when she's inviting Adora in. Sure, she's making it clear there is still a gap between them, but she might be willing to look for a way across it now. She doesn't believe Adora yet and Adora might not know what more she can try that she hasn't already, but that's not going to stop her from *fucking trying*. Adora presses a thumb under Catra's jaw, encouraging her to tilt her head up. It works, and they meet eyes again. Catra is trying to look annoyed, but her cheeks are warm from the proximity.

"Then I'll say it as many times as you let me. I still miss you every day. I never wanted to wake up without you," Adora tells her, seriously. Catra *squeaks*, which isn't brand new but certainly feels like it after so long. Catra ducks her head with the sound and Adora isn't holding her firmly enough to keep her in place as she pushes Adora forward so she can slide off the counter. Catra's tail bangs repeatedly against the cabinets as she steps to the side, turning away from Adora as if hiding her face makes a difference when her tail is going like *that*.

"Breakfast is going to get cold," Catra mutters. Adora takes a moment to drag her eyes down Catra's back—for multiple reasons. Aside from her tail lashing, she doesn't seem to be tensing too

much. Adora pushed her, but she isn't running, even if she's deflecting. Adora is at one out of a hundred, but she has to start somewhere. She takes a moment just to appreciate the view as she approaches Catra, watching her tense for a moment before Adora's hands find her hips and she presses against her back. She feels Catra relax against her as she nuzzles at the join of Catra's neck and shoulder, pressing a kiss to the abandoned ghost of a mark there.

"Fine, but when you're ready for what you asked for, I'll give it to you," Adora promises her, kissing her neck soft and open-mouthed. Catra huffs.

"I asked for food," Catra reminds her. Maybe Adora should be annoyed, but instead she smiles as she drops her hands from Catra and steps past her to the stove. It's such on brand petulancy for Catra that it just makes her fond. She smiles to herself as she finally takes their breakfast off the cooling stove and transfers it to the plates she abandoned when Catra walked in. Catra moves behind her as she works and Adora tracks her path over to the kitchen table in the back of her mind. She's still surprised when she turns around and sees her, but that's because she *forgot what she is wearing*. Or rather, what she isn't.

Catra throws her a smirk as she lounges back in the chair she either picked at random or just somehow knows is Adora's usual spot. She has one arm thrown back and hooked over the back, shifting the jacket so it just barely covers her, only effectively acting as a frame for everything that Adora wants to touch. It isn't a *hardship* to focus on the sexual side of things for now, but sitting through a breakfast and –at least mostly– keeping her hands to herself? Yeah, that's going to be hard, especially now her mind has shifted from thinking of this as hatesex –for Catra, at least– to hopefully the first day of many more, no matter how scattered they are as Catra comes and goes.

She just has to make it through breakfast. That isn't going to be easy with Catra throwing her that *I bet you want to kiss me* smirk, but she will absolutely be worth the wait.

Adora has never been patient.

Chapter End Notes

Yes Ihad to update the chapter count. This is jµst expected by now.

This Was Supposed To Be The Last One

Adora is a mess throughout breakfast. She knows better than to try and talk more at this point, and while "being patient" would normally frustrate her, right now she is quite distracted by Catra's *everything*. She would suspect that was Catra's plan except she's pretty sure Catra just wants to make her mess without the need for a further ulterior motive. Catra, despite her smug expressions and easy confidence – despite how she tries and somehow succeeds to take a bite off her fork seductively – is affected by Adora too. Adora sees her stealing looks in the brief moments where Adora "isn't looking" at her.

There's also the way she reaches out under the table, her tail finding its way into Adora's lap. That just gives Adora the chance to occasionally tug at it teasingly, though with it wrapped around Catra's body like this it doesn't really give her the stimulation that excites her. Catra's eyes still flare every time, and Adora isn't at all surprised when Catra pushes her plate away as soon as she is done, standing to walk the few steps to Adora and leaning over her in her seat. Catra's jacket has – at best – made an effort at covering her as she lounged in her seat, but bending down it does nothing except give Adora an artfully-framed eyeful as Catra grins at her.

"Think it's too early in the day for desert?" she asks, a sparkle in her eye because she knows Adora's answer is always going to be *no* regardless of if it's five A.M. It's not even that early, anyway, they were just up late.

Adora shoots up from her seat so fast that Catra has to whip her head back to avoid their foreheads colliding. Adora immediately blushes, locking eyes with a startled Catra for an infinite number of milliseconds before Catra bursts out laughing with an adorable little giggle mixed in that makes Adora want to kiss her, but if she did that then Catra would *stop* laughing, so that's unacceptable. Catra takes

Adora's hand before her laugh can even taper off, turning and leading Adora through her own house, back to the bedroom.

"You're so gay it makes you stupid," Catra tells her, voice still sparkling with amusement.

"Better than just being stupid all the time," Adora replies, smiling at Catra when they reach the bedroom and Catra turns around to take both of Adora's hands in her own, lacing their fingers again. Catra laughs again, for just a moment this time and sadly lacking the giggle, but she looks absolutely adorable with a smile on her face and her cheeks a little flushed from laughter.

"Only you would brag about being stupid," she says, fondly, as she tugs on their hands to encourage Adora to follow her as she backs up, bringing them to the edge of the bed.

"*Occasionally* stupid," Adora clarifies, because it's making Catra laugh and it's actually legitimately better than a lot of people out there who are running on poor decision-making 24/7. Like Sea Hawk. Catra doesn't laugh again, but her eyes sparkle as she drops one of Adora's hands and cups her head. Adora definitely counts it as a win when Catra pulls her in and their lips connect.

Their hands are still intertwined. Adora wraps her free arm around Catra's waist, sighing against her lips as their bodies press together. She feels at peace with Catra against her. Catra takes another step back and Adora feels when the back of Catra's legs bump into the mattress. For a moment, Adora pulls her closer, kissing her deeply and just enjoying holding her. As they kiss slowly, Adora slides her arm down so her hand can find Catra's thigh.

As much as she loves holding Catra's hand – it's so much more intimate than a lot of the touches they shared last night, no possible layer of lust-based denial to it – she reluctantly drops Catra's hand so she can reach down to grab her other thigh. She wants this, but she wants to have Catra in the bed more, worked up after Catra teasing her all through breakfast. Before she can lift her, however,

Catra pulls back and puts a finger over Adora's lips, still parted from kissing her and hanging open in confusion.

"Uh-uh, Princess," Catra scolds like she's talking to a misbehaving puppy. Adora's hands tighten on her, fingers sinking into the soft give of her thighs, holding her ground and waiting. Catra's eyes are sparkling. "It's my turn. You've gone too long without being put in your place," Catra purrs. Adora immediately draws in a sharp breath, heat sparking in her. An immediate *need* takes over her. A need to have, a need to be had, a need to rebel and then to *lose* that rebellion. Adora is gripping Catra tightly now, trying to think through her immediate haze of lust and let her brain settle on if she's going to take that as a challenge, or-

"C'mon. I know you haven't had anyone to behave for," Catra purrs, dropping her finger from Adora's lips and sliding her hand around her head again to pull her in for another kiss. As their tongues meet – because of course it's open-mouthed *immediately* – Adora melts in her hands. Reluctantly, she lets go of Catra's thighs, stroking her hands down them once to smooth the fur she ruffled up. Catra rewards her with an approving purr that immediately *ruins* Adora.

She'll do anything Catra says to get that purr again. She wraps her arms around Catra instead, holding on tight as she kisses her back and waits with anticipation humming in her blood, ready for Catra's next words. Speaking requires their lips parting though, and right now that's only happening for milliseconds at a time as they kiss as long and deeply as their air supply allows. It's a filthy kiss, maybe, but it isn't actually messy. It's so *purposeful*, a deep bond that feels as important as their fingers threaded together.

Catra is stretched up on her toes, Adora only realizes when Catra drops down to smile at her. It's a cocky grin, but far too meaningful to be a smirk.

"Good girl," Catra praises. Adora shivers as she feels Catra's claws trail up her thigh, not even pretending to care about the shirt covering her as she keeps going on her journey up Adora's body,

touch teasing as it keeps sweeping up past her hip and exposes her. It's not fair, hitting her at all angles at once and giving her no chance to recover. She has no hope of putting up the token protest that Catra did last night. Maybe she doesn't care, though. The game is exciting, but she already feels weak at the knees just from Catra's teasing promises. It has been so long.

Catra's eyes flick down, lust flaring in her eyes as her hand keeps traveling up to fondle Adora's tits beneath her shirt – not that beneath her shirt means *anything* when Catra has it pulled up this much so it's basically only draping over the one breast she isn't playing with and down her back. The look in Catra's eyes is familiar around the haze of lust, though, and Adora is pretty sure she's considering slicing through the shirt. It's laughably unnecessary, but clearly Adora's earlier assertion about not having bottomed *effected* Catra – or maybe this is just karma for last night – because she clearly wants control of her now.

Adora decides she likes this shirt and reaches up to remove it, tossing it aside and throwing Catra what she *intends* to be a triumphant smile, but it falls flat with how pleased Catra looks as she drops her other hand to play with both of Adora's tits at once. Okay, so that might have been her plan actually- Oh, she's purring again. Adora ducks forward, nudging her nose against Catra's cheek and being rewarded with Catra tilting her head up as she purrs louder, an extra roll of laughter to it.

Adora buzzes from their connected lips to her toes. She stumbles as Catra drops her hands to her hips and steers her towards the bed, but Catra doesn't stop kissing her, so she lets Catra lead her around blind, eyes closed and mind reduced to a warm, electrified haze. Catra called her easy at some point last night and she really wasn't wrong, but the addendum *for Catra* was missing. A few words and a teasing touch already have Adora on her knees. Actually, she would *love* to be on her knees for Catra and get to follow through on the tease from the kitchen, but she lets Catra encourage her back to the bed instead.

Climbing backwards onto it while still kissing Catra is kind of hard, and their lips part several excruciating times during it, but every time Adora releases a small, sad noise, Catra kisses her again, purring anew, so it's all okay. Catra frames her head in her hands, thumbs settling just beneath the corners of her jaw so she can tilt her head back how she wants as Catra straddles over her hips and takes control of the kiss. Her purr sadly fades, but she rolls her hips once for no reason other than to tease Adora and it effectively distracts her. Adora whines and Catra parts from her to chuckle, which only makes Adora whine *again*, although this time far more petulantly.

"Calm down, pillow princess," Catra purrs to her before nipping her bottom lip and tugging. Adora gasps out, turned on and *indignant*. Her hands fist the sheets and she tries to sit up a little, but Catra arches her back and pushes her back down with her tits, the zipper pull for her jacket digging in somewhere around Adora's abdominals.

"I am *not*," Adora protests, breathless as her hands find Catra's thighs again and *squeeze*, lifting a little to prove she could easily pick Catra up and flip them if she wanted to. Her protests only make Catra's eyes sparkle like she has found the greatest game of all. Catra leans in, her breath hot on Adora's face. For a moment Adora thinks she's going to kiss her to shut her up and her gaze betrays her by falling to Catra's lips, but Catra keeps going with a beautiful, infuriating sparkle in her eyes as she moves to whisper in Adora's ear.

"Sure you aren't, princess. And just for that, you're going to be face down in the pillows. Now *be good* and roll over," Catra purrs to her, her voice dripping in seduction. A shiver of arousal runs through Adora and she squeezes her eyes closed as she suppresses the urge to whine and instead just gasps a lot. She could fight. She has spent the last year topping and she *likes* it.

She also likes being good. She loves being Catra's. She likes being good in general, but none of those strangers had earned it, not the way Catra can with a few well-placed purrs and teases. Adora was steadfast then and it only makes it more important when she

reluctantly whines, eyes still shut, and drops her hands from Catra so she can roll over for her.

Catra's purr fills the air as she shifts back so Adora can move, reluctantly –"reluctantly"– rolling over onto her stomach and squishing her cheek into the pillow . Catra spent the morning scent marking it, and Adora rubs her cheek a little into it herself as she waits for Catra to straddle her again. Only she doesn't. Instead she nudges her knee between Adora's thighs, which makes sense and she shifts her legs to accommodate it, but the second Catra is settled between them she grabs Adora's hips and *pulls*.

Adora gasps out, trying to glance back over her shoulder and seeing approximately *nothing* as Catra pulls her hips up in a similar way that Adora did to her last night, only it feels completely opposite, and not just because she' s face down.

"Knees under you, princess. Ass up," Catra orders, a sparkle of laughter in her voice. Adora's mouth is simultaneous dry and salivating as she follows Catra's orders, letting Catra pull her up high enough that she can get her knees under her and brace herself between three points of contacts: each knee and her *face*, smothered into the pillow.

"Catra," she whines, a protest and a thank you and a *please*. Catra purrs again, the vibrations filling the air as she grabs Adora's ass with one hand and squeezes, claws digging in. Her other hand isn't innocent either, fingertips trailing up Adora's thigh, claws dragging, as she makes her way up to her folds and then the claws are conspicuously missing.

"Good girl," Catra praises, and the protest half of Adora' s whine is immediately gone. Adora gasps a little, but whether that is from horniness or the difficulty of breathing in this position is up in the air. "You're dripping for me. You can whine as much as you want, but we both know you love when I treat you like this," Catra purrs to her as her fingers slide through her folds, spreading that slick that negates any of Adora's arguments otherwise. She squeezes her eyes shut

and whines again because the words alone are making her light-headed.

She has been ruined in a matter of minutes – seconds, really. There was a lot of build-up all through breakfast, but topping preferences aside, Catra knows how she feels about Catra asserting dominance over her. Not having done this in over a *year* makes it so much more intense. She shifts her knee and gets an immediate and harsh spank that makes her cry out and stutter her hips, eyes flying open but not seeing anything. Her brain is just static and *please* at this point.

"Behave," Catra orders, her hand finding Adora's ass again and squeezing it. Adora whines, shifting a little to nod into the pillow, though that isn't very successful.

"I'm being good," she promises. Begs. Whichever results in Catra purring her satisfaction again as she spreads Adora's folds with her fingers.

"This belongs to me," Catra orders, as if that ever had to be asserted. It has been true even for the year they were broken up. Still are. Shit. Adora's mind is fuzzy and she just whines for a long moment. Catra's claws dig into her ass, a quiet threat – a promise, really.

"Yours, *please*," Adora promises, her voice far more pathetic than any of the begging she reduced Catra to last night, even three rounds in. Catra is purring again though, so it *doesn't matter*, not with those soothing vibrations in the air and Catra's fingers teasingly circling her clit. Adora moans and shifts her arms, bracing herself on them a *little* – still facedown, following the rules, but now able to breathe more freely. Even without the pillow pressed into her cheek, she's still panting, she's just that worked up and ready.

"*Good girl*," Catra rewards her, hand trailing up to her entrance. "Brace yourself," she warns, which is all the warning Adora gets before Catra plunges two fingers in. Adora's body is more than ready for it, but Catra has been looking at the mess she made of her and

knew that. The warning was for how Catra immediately fucks her without even giving her a moment to adjust, fingers plunging in and out at a brutal pace that has Adora letting out *ah*s into the pillow. She turns into it to try to muffle her sounds.

"Just like you fucked me last night, isn't it?" Adora, not really, but Adora whimpers out something that might be agreement into the pillow, "You love being made to bottom. You love how I fuck you, don't you?" Catra purrs to her. This time Adora manages words.

"*Yes*," she promises, breathless and lost as she rocks down into the bed with each of Catra's thrust. Catra's other hand has left her ass to instead hold her hip and try to brace her, but the entire bed still follows Catra's rhythm.

"Good girl," Catra praises, two words that Adora will never be tired of and that make her eyes flutter closed. Despite the praise, Catra's fingers pull out on the next thrust and *don't push back in*. Adora immediately gasps at the feeling of being empty, twitching her hips back like that will convince Catra to give her back her fingers. She did what Catra wanted, so she doesn't know why she's-

Catra's tongue meets her and Adora's thoughts turn to static. She's making moans that kind of sound like crying, twitching back as Catra licks against her and then seals her lips over her clit. It only lasts for a few moments of tantalizing stimulation before Catra pulls back and Adora feels utterly lost again, only this time Catra's spit is mixing with her slick.

Catra's fingers press in again, this time slower and more purposeful, an intrusion that has Adora shivering and moaning thankfully. Catra thrusts her fingers deep, this time forcing Adora to ride and appreciate every thrust without any of the urgency –and relief –of before. It's only in that moment that Adora realizes how torturous this is going to be. Whether it's Catra's fingers, or her tongue, or the fleeting stimulation she gives Adora's clit and then takes away on a whim, she is on a quest to *ruin her*.

She thought she was already there, but Catra reduces her to a whining, whimpering mess, made only worse when she twitches particularly hard and Catra murmurs *good girl* into her clit or rewards her desperation with a firm touch that is almost enough to bring her over, except then she backs off again and returns to torturing her. Adora doesn't know how long it lasts, only that she's vaguely begging, moaning, and maybe crying by the time that Catra decides she has been good enough and she presses in with a few stuttering thrusts, holding her fingers deep inside her as her hand finally leaves her hips to work her clit.

Even after all the build up, it takes Adora what feels like an *excruciatingly* long time –seconds –to come that she spends expecting Catra to pull away the stimulation again and deny her an orgasm. When it crashes over her, she pants and her knees finally drop out from under her as her back goes limp and the arch collapses. Catra's fingers are pulled out of her, sending another shock through her, as her hips collapse back onto the bed with her legs folded awkwardly beneath her.

None of that matters, because Adora is still gasping into the pillow and hearing static.

The first real thing she hears is Catra purring *good girl* in her ear as she crawls up to lay beside her.

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Adora takes a while to not be an utter mess. Eventually the sweat dries, she catches her breath, and she starts feeling like she needs to clean herself up at least a *little* so she reluctantly – *extremely* reluctantly –rolls out of Catra' s soft arms and makes a trip to the bathroom. She needs to clean up her face as much her inner thighs. She wasn't crying really, but eyes tend to water and run in sex like

that and her hair is a mess. She hasn't brushed it since she took it down from her ponytail last night and now she *really* needs to.

She returns to the bed with the afterglow perhaps a bit dimmed, but still feeling relaxed, deeply satisfied, and a little less like a bottom bitch mess. Catra looks smug as Adora makes her way back to the bed. Catra is also *naked* now, which is incredibly distracting despite how she was barely covered before. Her jacket has been carefully hung over Adora's chair on the other side of the room, so she must have gotten up while Adora was gone, but she lies melted in the sheets, watching Adora with amusement as she stands by the side of the bed and tries to figure out how she is going to get in it around Catra.

Adora runs a hand down over her back, petting her for a moment before she climbs over Catra to settle against the wall. Catra has chosen to turn into a puddle right in the middle of the mattress, so Adora's only option to not fall out – without moving her , at least – is to let the wall box her in. Catra rumbles as Adora stretches out beside her and returns to petting her, but she can only resist the temptation of that purr for so long before she's nudging closer to rest her cheek on Catra's back and feel it directly.

Catra either doesn't like it or she wants to cuddle more, because she rolls onto her side, dislodging Adora. Though it was a roll away, that leaves them facing each other, and Catra raises an arm to drape it over her side as she blinks slowly at her now that they're facing each other. Adora blinks back as a smile tugs at her lips. t' s just so good to see Catra melted – *softened* – in her bed, and she didn't even have to ply her with an orgasm to get her there. Well, not her own, anyway. Apparently working Adora over really was just that tiring.

Catra's eyes remain hooded and her soft purr doesn't stop as Adora shuffles closer – no longer pinned against the wall – so they can cuddle. She nudges her nose against Catra's cheek and gets rewarded with Catra tilting her chin up in a blatant invitation. The kiss is soft, practically chaste compared to the others they have shared this morning, but there is nothing about it that is *holding back*. No, it's

just soaking with the same lazy contentment that has Catra stretching out in the bed right now.

"That was incredible," Adora murmurs to her, their lips not even leaving contact for her to breathe the words. As soon as she has them out, they're kissing again. It's slow and decadent, a luxury she didn't think she would get to experience today, especially when Catra gives her a gentle rumble in reward. The kisses don't speed up, but they don't *stop* either. They just keep lazily making out for what must be minutes until Adora's blood is stirring again. She could easily relax into a nap with Catra, but she doesn't think Catra wants that just yet despite how boneless she seems right now. It's shocking she is this relaxed just from getting Adora off.

"Your turn?" Adora asks, still kissing Catra as she trails a hand down Catra's side invitingly. Her touch is light in case Catra really is done with sex for now – it's hard to tell, since she already seems content but is rarely ever *done* – but she wants to make the invitation. She kind of wants to earn back at least some of the dignity she just handed to Catra, too. There's nothing wrong with *bottom bitch* – who the hell would Adora get to top then – but it's far from what she's used to now and she wants to take care of Catra too, even with all of last night still fresh.

Catra pulls back from the kiss – by centimeters, but *still* – and tilts her head a little, seeming considering. She slits her eyes open to meet Adora's gaze as she shifts her legs together.

"I'm up for your hand," she decides, which Adora takes to mean she's still a little sore. She squeezes Catra's hip, carefully rubbing her thumb there so she doesn't tug on Catra's fur.

"Okay. Gentle?" she asks as she continues her path down to ghost her fingers through the fur right above where her thighs meet. Catra lets out a scoff, but there's no heat behind it.

"Unfortunately," she grumbles. She doesn't seem nearly as upset as she is implying and Adora smiles to her as Catra shifts her upper

thigh to give Adora better access. It's clear what she wants Adora to do, but Adora takes a minute to work her other arm under Catra, slipping it beneath her waist so she can splay her hand over Catra's back. Hopefully her forearm isn't painful to lay on. Catra seems distracted enough by twitching her hips up and trying to encourage Adora's hand further south that it at least isn't bothering her right now.

"Such a grumpy kitty," Adora says, grinning when that makes Catra narrow her eyes at her, but Adora kisses her before she can scowl. Catra kisses back as Adora cards her fingers through her fur and then slides them down to frame her vulva, never really touching her but certainly making Catra wriggle her hips and huff with frustration into the kiss. Adora runs her fingers up—away—and gets a warning growl. She chuckles and slides her hand back in place, but it *isn't* in place really, just beside where Catra wants it, and the ghosting touches are apparently too much. Catra pulls back and narrows her eyes at her, ears pinned back.

"Stop toying with me," she orders. That of course makes Adora want to do it more, but something about the way Catra's ears are pinned back halts her. She pauses, considering Catra. Can she really not take teasing right now? Adora was pretty sure all they were going to do was tease and push each other for the length of this rendezvous, but she was also pretty sure everything was going to end in the early hours of the morning, long before they could fall asleep together. Catra looks shy beneath Adora's uncertain gaze, her tail thumping once against the bed as she looks away.

"No games," she adds, her voice softer this time. It's meant to be clarity, and that thought is the only reason Adora—thinks—she finally understands Catra's words. She draws in a breath, raising her hand to place it cautiously on Catra's hip and ducking her head to draw her attention. Catra doesn't turn her face back to her, but she flicks her gaze over to meet her eyes again.

"Just us?" Adora clarifies, a little breathless. Catra's cheeks are warm and her ears are still pinned back, but she nods. Adora's heart

hammers. She pulls her arm out from under Catra and instead reaches up to cup her face. She strokes her thumb over Catra's cheek and watches her lean into it a little. Her ears are still pinned back, but Adora recognizes it as vulnerability – that thing Catra is so scared of – this time rather than discomfort. Well, discomfort from what Adora is doing.

Adora hasn't really bottomed in a year, but Catra probably has. Not to the extent that Adora just did, but in general, it has happened. *This*, what she is asking Adora for now, definitely hasn't. This still belongs solely to Adora. Adora coaxes her in to another kiss, this one slow and open-mouth, as she trails her hand from Catra's hip all along her body now. Catra doesn't want to be toyed with, but she wants Adora to do this *earnestly*, and that means Adora doing what she wants.

It means showing Catra what she wants – her. It means no layers of denial or even the distance of the last year. Adora isn't going to take long to touch Catra the way she wants, but she runs her hand all along her body first as she kisses her slow and soft. The kiss, despite its sweetness, feels a bit desperate. Adora *is* desperate, desperate to love Catra and desperately glad Catra is letting her do it for a few moments. Catra isn't much better. It feels like they're both afraid that the moment they part, the moment will be over.

"I love you," Adora breathes into Catra's mouth. Catra lets out a breathy laugh into the kiss, the kind of laugh people make when they're trying not to cry. Her hand lands on Adora's bicep and grips on *tight*.

"Already, huh?" she manages to laugh, but her voice has that same *could cry* quality to it that her laugh did. Adora's chest feels like there's a wild dove inside of it, flying erratically and banging against her ribs as it tries to find its way free. She squeezes Catra where her hand happens to be at the moment, just above her waist on its way down from fondling her.

"Always," she promises. Catra lets out a small, needy sound and kisses her harder. Their lips aren't about to part. That would mean confronting what they're doing. Catra knows – at least, Adora hopes – that Adora never stopped loving her , but the *already* is a fair comment on how quickly Adora said it after being given anything that could be construed as permission to.

Adora ducks her head and Catra immediately whines, the sound a little anxious, but it tapers off as Adora's lips find her neck and her hand finally slides to meet her. Catra is wet. Nothing like the soaking mess Adora was, but her fingers glide over her without much resistance as they finally find her clit. Catra gasps out, tilting her head back and offering her neck, apparently now willing to let the kiss go.

"I love you," Adora breathes into her skin this time as her fingers slowly circle her, gentle and careful. She wonders if Catra is even still sore or if that's all an excuse for Catra to lay back and take it *soft*. Catra whines high-pitched now, trembling a little beneath her touch. Adora's chest feels like she just took a deep breath on a freezing night, every one of her nerve endings on high alert.

"One second. I'll be right back, I promise," Adora assures her right before she pulls her hand away from her. Catra still makes an anxious sound in her throat, especially when Adora sits up to free the arm she's laying on. Catra's eyes fly open and watch her with a burning gaze as Adora lays back down, rearranged so she can use both hands to touch Catra. She lifts the fingers she had been running over her up to her own mouth, holding eye contact with Catra as she dips them in.

There isn't much slick on them – Catra isn't that wet and Adora isn't going to try to finger her in case she is too sore for it – but the taste is still there, and she watches Catra's pupils sharpen as she *watches* Adora's movement. Adora pulls her fingers out of her mouth as her other hand cups the length of Catra's slit. She trails her fingers back up to touch her clit again as she turns her hand and offers it to Catra.

Catra's gaze flicks down and she licks her lips, but after a moment she meets Adora's gaze again and parts her lips.

Adora presses her fingers between Catra's lips. She's sharing her spit more than she's making Catra taste herself, but Catra's breath still puffs out in hot pants against her hands as Adora slowly thrusts her fingers into and out of Catra's mouth. Catra's face is flushed, but her eyelids are starting to droop into a hooded gaze. She's relaxing into the attention and that's the thought that has Adora pulling her fingers out so she can kiss her again. Catra immediately meets her with all the needy desperation of their last kiss.

Adora sets a rhythm with her hand on Catra as she absently wipes the other one on the sheets. It isn't exactly dry, but she won't trail spit through Catra's fur now as she runs her hand over her. She needs to touch her in every way, to surround Catra in her touch, and though that means she's using the hand with less leverage to actually get Catra off, doing it slow and sweet isn't a downside to her.

"I love you," Adora murmurs to her. Catra lets out a growly little trill into the kiss, which only makes Adora want her tongue in Catra's mouth, but she tilts her head back and breaks the kiss before Adora can make that happen or even really appreciate the growl.

"Cool it. You never used to say it this much." That is a filthy lie and Catra certainly doesn't sound like she *wants* Adora to stop anyway. Her tail thuds heavily against the bed just like it did before. Anxious.

"You used to know it. I used to be able to show it with how I touched you," Adora replies, squeezing Catra's hip to illustrate her point. She used to love murmuring adorations into Catra's skin as she fucked her, or even when they were just laying in bed together, but it wasn't something that happened every time—it never *needed* to be. No, that was reserved for when Adora just couldn't contain herself anymore. Adora has barely been able to keep her cool throughout this whole thing, thrilled to have Catra with her again.

Catra face is flushed as she looks at the wall, biting her lip. Then, slowly, her eyes close and sqeez shut.

"T ouch me like that again," she breathes, her voice *fragile*.

"Okay . Believe me," Adora asks, a whispered prayer before she sets to doing just that. She kisses her , and she runs her hands over her, not even dedicating one to getting her off. No, she slides both her hands along her, sqeezing and feeling, appreciating and greedy and guilty all in turn, and when one of her hands drifts south she touches Catra until she can't stand keeping her touch still any longer and needs to run it over every part of her again. Catra shivers and moans into her mouth, shifting beneath her hands until every twitch and jerk of her body makes Adora feel guilty for stringing her out and she finally dedicates one hand to working her over.

She never stops touching her with the other, though, cataloging every inch of her skin that she has missed in the past year as Catra keens, mewls, and then finally comes, collapsing against the bed with tears in her eyes. Adora cups her with her hand for a long moment before she finally pulls it away and wraps Catra in her arms, pressing soft kisses into her hair and over her ears.

"That was beautiful. Y ou're beautiful. Ilove you like this," Adora tells her as Catra draws in deep breaths with the rattling edge of purr to them. *Ike this* , when Catra is willing to be vulnerable beneath Adora's touch, is important. owering her armor risks being met with nothing, exposed and let down, but Adora would never do that to her. She knows Catra just had her reduced to a writhing, crying mess, begging for Catra to give her release, but this somehow felt more vulnerable. Catra was domineering, toying with her. For Catra's turn, she gave herself over, luxuriating in Adora's love rather than being reduced to ash beneath her touch.

Catra swallows and it's *audible* as she tries to get her breathing under control. Adora hugs her, resisting the urge to sqeez her close and make it even harder for her to breathe normally. Catra's

eyes flutter open as she equalizes, her face still flushed but her gaze sharp and aware again. Her pupils, though – her pupils are round.

"That was," Catra licks her lips, "good," she settles on. Adora laughs, feeling her eyes crinkle up as she lifts a hand to brush some of Catra's choppy bangs out of her face. It's so Catra to follow up something like *that* with a middling response. Not ready to dismiss it, but unable to make herself vulnerable enough to answer honestly.

"Thanks, I'll be sure to add that to my three-star reviews," Adora says. Catra laughs that *giggly* laugh again as she shoves at Adora's shoulder.

"Oh, shut up," she says. And then, like she hadn't *just* pushed Adora away, "Come back here," she orders, already wrapping her arms around Adora's shoulders. Adora grins as she shuffles in, wrapping Catra in her arms and leaning their foreheads together. She runs her hands over Catra, though the touch is distinctly different now. It isn't about loving and memorizing every inch of her. Adora just wants to cuddle and, apparently, so does Catra. Showing her what a touch without intent feels like after *that* will hopefully hammer in how much feeling was behind it too.

Adora ducks her head to nuzzle into Catra's neck, finding Catra's post-orgasm purr is rolling there, just very quiet. That's not right, not *enough*. She wants her to rumble for her. Did she not earn it? What was she missing? She runs her hands over Catra like she'll find the answer in the dip below her hip bone. Though quiet, Catra's purr is distinctly there, so Adora has to satisfy herself with burying her face in the crook of her neck so the vibrations can roll straight into her.

Catra arches a little into her hands as they sweep over her, lazily shifting up but still clearly appreciating the touches. It took three rounds to get Catra to her needy, cuddly, post-orgasm state last night, but just one session like this is enough today. Fuck, Adora loves her so much. She loves her buzzing purr, the way she pulls Adora close, the flex of her body beneath her hands as she arches up into each touch. The cuddles are just as amazing as the sex. Of

course they are: it's time being intimate with Catra. Whether *intimate* means emotionally or sexually, it's all Adora wants.

"I never want to stop touching you," Adora murmurs into Catra's neck before she presses a kiss there. And then another as Catra chuckles and her purr buzzes a little louder.

"What about earlier when you went to the bathroom?" she asks, because she loves to be difficult. Adora has, realistically, stopped touching Catra many times today, but she certainly never *wanted* to and right now it sounds like it might actually kill her.

"That was scary," Adora agrees, because if Catra can make things difficult for her than she can make it difficult for Catra to be difficult. Catra laughs, light and amused.

"Scary?" she questions with a high edge of incredulity to her voice. Her purr gets louder whenever she speaks and Adora sighs, relieved, against her throat before kissing her neck again.

"You weren't there," she replies, words muffled. She's committing because it made Catra laugh, but yeah, it's kind of true. She doesn't want Catra to leave again, and she might if Adora isn't in the room to be hot enough to tempt her into staying. Or something. That logic kind of made sense before the last round.

"You're ridiculous," Catra says, her voice breathy. It could be because Adora is kissing her, or it could be something else. Catra's purr picks up when she speaks and doesn't dim, though, so Adora sets to peppering kisses along her throat because it's either that or burst out that she loves her, which is probably not welcome this far from sex. Catra didn't say the games were back on, but Adora isn't an idiot. The purr and memories are all she gets to keep from that.

Adora shifts up to nudge her nose against Catra's cheek.

"Kiss me while you purr?" she asks, because if Catra can be vulnerable so can she. Not that this is nearly as vulnerable as Catra

letting down her walls, but Catra could very well laugh at her. She does laugh, actually, but it's a brief chuckle before she tilts her chin up and kisses Adora. She *purrs*, loud and rumbling, building in her chest until it puts the bass from the club to shame. Logically, it's not even a fraction of the volume, but Adora breathes it in and feels it down to her toes.

She presses in closer to Catra so their chests are tight together and she can feel the rumble as well as taste it. It's kind of hard to kiss while Catra is purring – for both of them – but it makes all of the hair on Adora's arms stand on end and her scalp tingle until they're forced to part. As Catra draws in air, Adora nuzzles into her neck again. She still feels a little electric, but the rumble goes a long way towards soothing her.

"You're such a freak," Catra accuses once she can breathe again, though she just sounds amused. "What, couldn't find any other magicats to follow you home?" she asks as if that has *any* bearing on why Adora wants to kiss her like this.

Yes, Adora fixates on sensations and Catra's purr has been a major one in her life since long before her school counselor recommended she see a specialist that she was never sent to, but any magicat wouldn't do. Adora might prefer her drums over a stranger.

"Once. It was gross," Adora mumbles into Catra's neck. Catra pauses – as does her purr – and Adora feels Catra's chin shift against the top of her head as Catra tilts her head. Her tail curls forward, sweeping over Adora's legs and wrapping around them.

"Gross?" she questions, clearly thrown for a loop. There's a dark edge to her voice, too. Adora squeezes her a little tighter, pressing her face into her and breathing in the softness of her fur for a long moment before she reluctantly pulls back and breathes real air.

"My thoughts were. My brain kept trying to pretend she was you – which is fucked up to start – but she also *wasn't*. She might have looked more like you than the others, but that just messed me up. I

wasn't missing your *looks*," Adora admits. She's ashamed of it, and she doesn't know if it's going to make Catra angry, but instead Catra just stares at her. Catra blinks, and it's slow. She could just be in shock, but the simple action helps Adora feel better, so she pitches forward and squeezes Catra close, wrapping around her.

She presses them so tight together she thinks Catra, with her mild but still present claustrophobia, would be getting uneasy in any other scenario, but after several long seconds Catra hugs her back. Not nearly as tightly as Adora is hugging her, but *duh*.

"I missed that little growl you give when I pin your legs down. I missed the way I just feel *fond* when you're being obtuse. I missed that arrogant smile you give me when you've just managed something incredible with a bike. I missed when you give me shit. I even missed waking up with your hair in my mouth. I missed how everything *matters* when I'm with you. She wasn't you. None of them were." It's a flood, a half dozen little things that Adora has thought about and she could probably give a hundred more, but she has the sense to stop when her breath runs out.

Catra sucks in a sharp breath. Adora can only partially see her face with them cuddling together this tight, but she knows a line has been crossed.

Might as well cross one more. She pulls back enough to make eye contact, wide eyes meeting wide eyes.

"Stay the night?" she asks. It's a stupid question, and it's also not the one she's really asking, but she isn't ready for Catra to go, even if she's sure Catra will be coming back around eventually after what they just did. Catra swallows, her tail thudding once against the mattress.

"It's like, noon," she says, her voice a little strained.

"It's two, actually," Adora corrects, like that makes any difference. She saw it was past one when she got up to use the bathroom, so

it’s probably about two now. Roughly. Catra’s eyes flick away.

“That wasn’t the point,” she says. Adora knew she was going to say no, realistically, but fuck, she *hoped*. She blows out a rough sigh, forcing her disappointment down. Burdening Catra with her emotions isn’t going to convince her to come back around.

“I can’t tonight,” Catra adds in a whisper . The strained words make Adora suck in a sharp breath, her chest and *hope* expanding with it. Catra’s ears are pinned back and she looks nervous. Adora lifts a hand to cup Catra’s cheek, offering her a small, hopeful smile when their eyes meet.

“T onight, huh?” she manages to make it sound teasing instead of utterly relieved. Catra’s tail drums against the bed, just the end flicking but still managing to make an impressive amount of sound. After a moment, Catra sits up and turns away. Adora’s heart jumps and falls as she watches Catra face the foot of the bed, bending her knees up partially so she can lean over them.

Catra raises both her hands and runs them through her hair, ruffling her ears and running her hands down her face too for good measure, as if she can shake away whatever thoughts she is having. She heaves a sigh as she braces her elbows on her knees, almost folded in half. Adora sits up cautiously, edging closer so she can settle against Catra’s back, giving her a bit of support without forcing her to look at her.

Catra doesn’t react. Adora kisses her shoulder.

“W ant to talk about it?” she of fers. Catra laughs, a quiet chuckle, but she bends one of her arms back so she can place her hand over Adora’s on her hip.

“Of course not,” Catra says. It’ s Adora’s turn to laugh. She knew that was coming. The offer would have been far too hopeful if she actually had any hope of Catra agreeing. She just wanted to show her support. She gives Catra a moment to think as she kisses along

her shoulder and reaches the back of her neck. She presses a soft but lingering kiss against the scar there. The fur on Catra's shoulders puffs up a little.

"This feels good," Catra whispers after a moment, like it's a dirty secret. Adora smiles as she presses another kiss, even softer this time, to the edge of the scar where there's still a slight bit of scabbing.

"Almost like we're good," there's a mischievous lilt to her voice because she expects Catra to have a reaction to that, and she does. All of Catra's fur puffs up and she lets out a little yelp, like it's a *surprise*. Maybe it's her attempt at a protest or she really wasn't expecting Adora to give it voice, but she doesn't pull away as Adora nuzzles into her short hair.

"Shut up. Asshole," Catra grumbles. She does not sound upset. Adora smiles.

"So are you," she replies. Catra huffs and her tail twitches, but she doesn't pull away. She doesn't even let go of Adora's hand. After a few seconds, she leans back a little more and Adora shifts to properly wrap her arms around Catra's waist so she can support her. Catra lets out a sigh that rings through the empty room.

"I felt like you didn't care," she whispers, and oh, they're *talking* about it. Adora draws in a sharp breath, tightening her arms around Catra for a moment in a silent hug.

"I did. I do so much. We just thought different things showed that," Adora promises her. She still doesn't get why Catra stayed except for spite, but they've yelled at each other enough for Adora to know why that spite was *there*. Catra never wanted to be rescued.

Catra is silent for several long moments.

"Yeah. But how can that ever work?" she replies. Her voice is too quiet to give anything away. Adora hugs her tighter again.

f we try . And listen,"Adora says. She really thinks they could make it work, but they both have to want to. They worked before and their relationship wasn't exactly stress-free with the Horde hanging over them.

"All you've done for the last year is try to convince me that you were right,"Catra returns, her voice a little louder from the edge of annoyance to it. Adora frowns, shifting her arms so she can run one hand down Catra's side to soothe her.

"Y ou made it very clear how you felt. t didn't feel like you were listening to my side, just insisting what my intentions were. Iwasn't- I wasn't right, okay? Regardless of intentions. But neither were you," Adora says. t' s kind of painful to admit, but there it is. Catra pulls her knees all the way up to her chest and wraps her arms around them, her ears twitching back as she sulks. Adora's arm is left trapped between Catra's waist and legs.

"Idn't feel like *you* were listening,"she grumbles back. Adora actually smiles to herself, dropping another kiss to Catra's shoulder. She loves her, even –maybe *especially* –when she' s petulant.

"So maybe we could try actually talking?"Adora suggests. Catra releases a bratty whine that has Adora kissing her neck another half-dozen times and nuzzling into her hair . "Y ou're so cute,"she informs her. Catra huffs, but she also tilts her head to give Adora more access.

For a few moments she sits like that, thinking while Adora kisses her and waits, and then Catra seems to decide that there have been enough emotions for the day because she lets go of her knees and *flings* herself backwards with enough force to send Adora sprawling. Adora lets out a very elegant "Guh!"as Catra knocks the air out of her. Catra laughs at her, wriggling around on her chest and only making it harder to breathe. Before Adora can catch her bearings, Catra has settled down stretched out over her, face buried between the pillow and Adora's shoulder with her ears twitched back to keep Adora from breathing into them.

I'm going to sleep," Catra declares, because she's allergic to feelings. Adora sighs, but it's fond. She wraps her arms around Catra and strains forward to kiss the top of an ear before she drops back down and lets Catra have her way. Catra doesn't want to talk about it anymore, fine. Adora is pretty sure she is going to be thinking about it regardless of what she pretends to be doing.

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They lay still together for a good twenty minutes. Adora can just barely see the clock from where she's laying and she still can't see all of it, but she isn't really paying attention to how long it has been anyway. A few minutes in Catra started purring softly and Adora has been in a pretty blissful state since then. A part of her worries that Catra is purring to self-soothe – Adora knows her girlfr- knows Catra enough to know that no matter how peaceful she looks, her mind must be going a mile a minute right now – but the longer it goes on the less she worries about that.

She's kind of hoping Catra will fall asleep and maybe it'll be late enough for lunch when she wakes, and then Catra will want to go again, and then she'll be so comfortable afterwards she'll decide to stay one more night after all, but Adora knows that's just a daydream. She has to be at the track tomorrow morning anyway. She plans her nights out well and she didn't have anything she had to do today, but if the girl she brought home hadn't been Catra, she probably would have turned up at the track today anyway.

She has been told to hang around there less and focus on developing her whole life rather than the single aspect of it that gives her adrenaline – which was *harsh* of Angella, even if she's right – but apparently her absence has been noted. A knock pounds on her front door and Catra practically leaps in the air, scrambling up with all

her fur puffing out and whipping her head in the direction of the sound to growl at it.

Adora, despite how it's probably going to get her in trouble, laughs and reaches up to pet down the fur on Catra's shoulders. Catra huffs, still growling vaguely and glowering at the wall.

"You have twenty seconds to deal with that before I flay whoever it is with my claws," she grumbles, dropping back down onto the bed – this time beside Adora – with a frowny pout. Adora very quickly sits up. Catra makes a lot of threats, but even though she rarely follows through on the violent ones to the letter, that doesn't mean she doesn't *follow through*.

Adora climbs out of bed and hurries down the hall with Catra's laugh echoing behind her, apparently amused at the concern that her words light in Adora. Adora doesn't glimpse anyone through the small window at the top of the door, which means either a package was dropped off or it's Glimmer. When she unlocks and opens the door, sure enough it's her friend who is too short to see through the window without Adora standing on her toes, but she was not expecting her reaction.

"Ach! Why are you naked!" Glimmer yells, hurrying to cover her face and flushing. Adora blushes in time with her, glancing down and quickly swinging the door shut, leaving just a sliver open to talk to Glimmer through without her having to shield her eyes.

"I forgot!" she calls through the door. She can hear Catra cackling in the next room over. She's a fucking traitor and Adora wouldn't expect anything less of her. No wonder she was laughing as she left.

"You forgot you were *naked*? Do you usually answer the door like this?" Glimmer asks, her voice high and incredulous. Stretching up on her toes lets Adora peak through the glass half-circle. It's made from privacy glass and distorts what's on the other side, but she can tell Glimmer is still holding one hand in front of her eyes.

"No! I don't know!" Adora shouts back, flustered and quietly cursing Catra in the next room, *still* laughing. They've spent so much time wearing nothing – or basically nothing – this morning that she just didn't register it.

"What do you mean you don't know?" Glimmer asks, her voice still just as high. If possible, Adora flushes worse.

"No, I don't," she changes her answer, despite how she can't promise that. She doesn't spend time naked unless she's *doing* something – someone – but given that it didn't even occur to her this time? Yeah, it could have happened. She's pretty sure it hasn't, though.

"Do you just hang around the house naked?" Glimmer asks. Apparently Adora has really broken her brain and she's trying to piece back together her world view one question at a time.

"No! I was- in the middle of something," she protests, starting off strong and ending in a flustered hiss. There's a long pause in which Adora is *sure* Catra is still snickering at her, but without magic at hearing she doesn't have to listen to it through the wall.

"Do you have someone over? *Still*? What round is it?" Glimmer asks, and at least her voice isn't high and strangled anymore, but she's openly incredulous. Adora's face is burning. Glimmer noticed her going out last night, then, but at least she didn't see who she brought home.

"I lost count," Adora mumbles. What counts as a round, anyway? She feels like there has to be a minimum amount of time between orgasms to count and she isn't about to start tracking that. It's just vibes for her and with how much they have done, it all kind of blends together.

"You- Alright. I was just checking in on you, anyway. We'll, um, talk later," Glimmer decides, clearly still flustered. Adora nods, relieved, at the door that Glimmer can't see the gesture through.

"I'll like, come by at dinner or something," Adora promises. An awkward "Right, see you later" and then she hears Glimmer's footsteps retreating. Adora closes her door the rest of the way, cringing a little. From the bedroom, she hears a movement. She locks the door and heads back down the hall, already preparing to cross her arms and send Catra a glare when she reaches the doorway, but she stops when she sees Catra standing up and in the middle of putting back on her pants from last night.

Catra glances up and meets her gaze as Adora feels her expression flicker, but she manages to rally and put her glare back on – even if it's a pout at this point – as she leans against the doorframe.

"You could have warned me," she complains. Catra's face breaks into a grin as she tamps down her patch of thicker fur and does up her fly carefully without any underwear to protect her.

"I liked how it went," she hums, mischief sparkling in her voice. Adora's face is still red. Yeah, she *bets*. She wonders what she should say as Catra casts around the room for her shirt, forgotten since last night. Adora has just settled on *you don't have to go* when Catra bends to grab the crop top and freezes, her gaze fixed off to the side.

"Catra?" Adora questions, frowning for real now as she pushes off the doorframe. Catra's tail swings to the side and then curls back the other way.

"Is that a unicorn?" she asks, straightening up but keeping her gaze fixed on the shadowed gap between the bottom of Adora's bed and the floor. Oh, Adora thought she was flushing before, but somehow this is worse.

"I don't know what you're talking about," she deflects as Catra pulls on her shirt. It's too late. Catra is already walking to the edge of the bed. Adora always shoves the stuffed toy under there before she goes out for the night in case she brings someone home. Catra reaches under the bed and pulls out the oversized plush with a hand

at the base of its neck, like it's a kitten with a scruff. For a long moment, she stares at it.

"Adora," she says, barely holding in a laugh as she tilts the unicorn, inspecting it. She turns back around, holding the unicorn up beside her face so Adora is forced to look them both in the eyes at once. "How much did you spend on this?" Catra asks, the corner of her mouth *twitching* as she tries to contain herself. Adora huffs, crossing her arms over her chest and looking away.

"Only a little more than I did on our strap," she mutters. Catra bursts out laughing. Honestly, that's a great price for a plush that's like two feet long. She saw it when she went to a boardwalk with Glimmer and Bow. They were trying to get her to take a weekend vacation and instead she ended up with the plush for... frankly pathetic reasons.

"I needed something to cuddle with you gone, okay?" Adora defends, her voice a little high. Catra stops laughing, but the amusement is still sparkling in her eyes as she turns and puts the unicorn down on the bed.

"Oh, and something with a sparkly orange mane that can get plastic in your face makes a lot more sense than a body pillow," Catra agrees. Adora isn't really embarrassed, but she's definitely flustered as Catra turns to where she hung her jacket and pulls it on. Being the only one naked when Catra is now fully dressed isn't helping.

"It's authentic to the experience of getting your mane in my mouth," Adora shoots back, stepping into the room and reluctantly making her way to the closet. She isn't going to bust out her argument that a pillow is nothing while a stuffed animal at least feels like it has a little personality. She'll either seem like she's five or freakishly lonely. Catra makes an indignant noise, but she throws Adora a mischievous grin.

"Is there more? Am I missing anything else fun in here?" Catra asks, glancing around the room. Adora flushes as she turns away to yank

open the closet door. Anything else stuffed animal related? No. Anything else that would make Catra mock her if she found it? Yes, definitely. There's something in the cubby Adora is pulling her underwear out of, even.

"A set of lingerie I bought for myself and a bloodstained shirt," Adora admits as she pulls on her underwear. There's a moment of silence as she picks out a sports bra and yanks it on.

"Bloodstained?" Catra questions, voice exactly as confused and surprised by that as it probably should be. Adora considers her options in her closet and grabs a shirt that is too tight for her and she probably should have thrown out by now, but it's kind of comforting to wear, like a hug, and she's sure Catra will appreciate it.

"From a whiplash nosebleed. I'm mostly mentioning it so you don't panic when you find it," she replies. She *knows* Catra is going to go digging in her closet at some point. She already did, actually, when she stole Adora's shorts, she just didn't happen across anything fun when she did it.

"Why haven't you thrown it away?" Catra sounds baffled. Adora turns around and finds Catra standing behind her, sending her an incredulous look with her eyebrow raised. Adora shrugs as she steps around Catra and bends to pick up the shorts Catra borrowed from where they were discarded on the floor. Catra's eyes dilate as she watches Adora pull them on. They aren't damp anymore, but they definitely aren't *clean*. That's why Adora picked them, though. She was hoping it would get a reaction from Catra.

"In case I end up in a situation where I think I might bleed again, so I don't have to stain two shirts," Adora offers. Nosebleeds or small injuries happen on the track. It isn't that weird to plan for. If it's during practice, she doesn't have to be in her full uniform and she can wear a regular shirt under her padding. Bow thought it was gross too, but Glimmer just kind of sighed and waved her hand, so that was as good as agreeing to Adora. Catra, for her part, stares at her with her ears twitching.

"Your idiocy makes me want to fuck you on the floor," she says. Adora flushes to her ears and probably right down to her shoulders. That's okay.

"I mean, we could," she replies, her voice high. This isn't the first time that Catra has said something that could translate to a thought like that, but Adora wasn't ready for it. She was expecting Catra to laugh at her. Catra lets out a sharp, disappointed sigh and rolls her eyes up to the ceiling.

"No, I need to go back and make sure Entrapta hasn't blown up the place," she says despite seeming annoyed with the idea. Adora considers her for a moment.

"At least let me drive you home?" Adora asks. She isn't ready to be done, but clearly Catra is going. Any extra time she gets will have to be on the drive. Catra is quiet, her eyes dropping from the ceiling slowly, only now she looks down at her hands as she pulls her phone out of her jacket pocket. She doesn't meet Adora's eyes.

"No, you can't," she decides. Adora's shoulders fall as Catra calls up a rideshare.

She has known this moment—this good, beautiful day—was going to end from the moment she woke up with Catra, but she never could be ready for it when it came. After Catra gets an estimated wait time of fifteen minutes, Adora takes her hand with a hopeful look and leads her into the living room that Catra hasn't even seen yet. Catra looks wary, but Adora doesn't try to talk. Instead, she kisses her. After only a few seconds, Catra melts against her.

They make out for the seventeen minutes it takes before Catra's phone buzzes.

Back To The Track

Chapter Notes

Aw man here we go

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sits on her couch after Catra leaves and tries to process, but her mind mostly feels like static. The cushions are still warm from where they were settled together and it's pretty much all she can think about, this warm spot the only lingering trace of Catra's presence except for the claw marks down her back. Adora flexes her shoulders, grateful for the slight stretch she feels there, proof she was in Catra's arms. A few spots on her neck are gently throbbing from the make out, but as much as Adora likes them, she's had hickies from hook-ups before. The clawmarks are *Catra's*.

She misses her already. She should really go up to the house and let Glimmer and Bow distract her if they're still home, but then Glimmer is going to ask questions about who she had over. Talking about Catra—or more likely, getting a lecture about her—isn't exactly a good distraction from missing her. Adora isn't going to make good on her promise of dinner. She can already feel the sadness creeping in now Catra's gone and being mopey isn't going to help her case when she does try to convince her friends that this was all a good thing, actually.

After trying to busy herself with doing the dishes and taking a shower—she traces her fingers over the bruises forming on her neck in the mirror gratefully before she leaves the bathroom—she gives up on trying to pretend it's a normal day and goes for her drums instead. They're a poor imitation of Catra's purr. Not that they ever helped in the same way, but after getting to feel how Catra's purrs and growls buzz through her blood again, the drums feel almost jarring in

comparison. Crashing, inelegant, and on the wrong rhythm even when she's on-beat to the song.

No matter how clumsy it feels, the music is better than silence. It was so good having Catra around again and she feels adrift without her, on an endorphin crash that has her arms shaking with barely any exertion. She can go for a long time – her longest record is 2 hours, actually, before Glimmer showed up ready to snap her drumsticks in half and cut her off early – but just a few minutes in and she's barely able to hold her rhythm.

Catra is coming back – she *is* – but how long will that take? Days? Weeks? Adora misses her like a lost limb. It felt so right to have her around again. She wants to take her face in her hands, trace the paths of her freckles with her fingertips, and kiss her softly and sweetly enough that Catra *has* to believe she loves her. She held back so much while Catra was here, trying to keep from upsetting her so she *would* come back, but with her gone the dam breaks and her carefully bottled emotions rush through her.

Adora's rhythm breaks in a clatter as one of her drumsticks skitters off mark and she gives up on distraction, arms dropping in the middle of the beat with the crash of the cymbals still reverberating through the air. She pants and it's only half from exertion. Her heartbeat is following the pace of the emotions rushing through her head, not the music. She tosses the drumsticks aside with uncharacteristic carelessness and reaches for her phone instead.

Texting Entrapta is pretty much the only thing she can do to help repair their relationship now that Catra has left. It's a simple greeting and invitation to talk if Entrapta ever misses the track, but it feels better to have done something that might help bring Catra back into her life. She's good friends with Entrapta now and might come visit her with plenty of opportunity to deny that she wanted to see Adora too. Without access to her own garage, they might even take to working on Melog back at the track. They're not supposed to do stuff like that, but Angella let Entrapta get away with a lot of things she

wasn't supposed to, both because she was fond of her and because it was the price of Entrapta's work.

t takes a few moments in which Adora wipes sweat from her forehead –just because she can play for a lot longer doesn't mean it isn't a workout –before she gets a reply , which is pretty good for Entrapta. Sometimes she's a fast replier and sometimes she gets absorbed in a project for thirty-six hours and her phone becomes dead to her.

Ogreat! Are you sure Angella would want me back? Entrapta sends back, an uncharacteristic worry for her. Adora frowns, but she texts back to assure Entrapta that there's always room for her. Entrapta says she'll come by the track after she's done with her current project and then Adora' s screen becomes a wall of text as Entrapta tries to explain her project to her . t would probably take Adora a week to decipher it, and by then Entrapta would probably be done. Adora just goes with, *wow, cool!*

Entrapta assures her it's very cool and says she needs to get back to it, leaving Adora once again with nothing to do but wait.

She hates waiting.

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Adora shows up at Angella's office in the mid-morning the next day looking like shit. She didn't sleep well in her empty bed. t isn't exactly new, but it feels worse after a night of solid, peaceful sleep with Catra at her side to contrast it to. Angella gives her a *look* when she walks into the office with red impressions under her eyes – Adora wishes her eyebags weren't so violent and obvious, but they're always like this when she has cried recently, which she did last night just because she missed Catra and emotions are like that

at two A.M. – but Angella saves the lecture for after Adora has dropped down into a seat, tucking her knees up to her chest and rocking back and forth a little as she explains the situation with Entrapta and the Horde as Catra told it yesterday.

She probably shouldn't be so candid talking about the Horde, but Angella proved she could be trusted shortly after Glimmer and Bow proved that they could. She frowns as she listens and then starts typing on her computer, but she nods along for the whole recounting of the story until Adora has run out of information and instead begun to drum her knuckles against the arm of the chair, unable to be still.

She needs to get out on the track. She shouldn't when she's tired, but she needs to. Angella probably won't let her.

t' s kind of like how she needs Catra but it isn't up to her.

"I'll reach out myself. Even if we've arranged the facility to run without her, I'll do what I can to bring her back to a healthy atmosphere," Angella promises, evading saying anything outright acknowledging criminal intent all while still typing away on her computer. She could be emailing Entrapta right now for all Adora knows. She nods, tapping as she tries to figure out how to ask Angella if she can go out on the track in a way that won't get her grounded.

Basically grounded, anyway. Literally stuck on the ground with her two feet. Whatever. Angella has just sent a *glance* to Adora's rapidly tapping hand when the door opens with barely half a knock in warning. They both turn to find Juliet stepping through the door, not a hair out of place, but her breathing is heavy enough to give away that she was rushing.

"Ma'am, Entrapta is here? She said she was supposed to be but she doesn't have clearance anymore and nobody was briefed on an update," Juliet asks.

Adora and Angella both blink at her. That was fast.

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Apparently, no one really tried to stop Entrapta and that's why Juliet was in such a hurry. When they reach Entrapta's old garage, Entrapta is already moving about the space and humming to herself as she rearranges the tools. No one ever considered Entrapta a *threat* to anyone, so it's kind of hard to tell her to stop and still feel like you're being reasonable, but there are protocols and Juliet pretty much exists to enforce them, so Adora is surprised to see she got so far.

"Entrapta, it's lovely to see you," Angella greets from behind Adora as they enter the garage, composed as ever, except Adora saw her when she first heard and she was just as surprised. Entrapta whips around with a grin on her face, shooting an arm up and waving brightly. Adora walks deeper into the space a bit dazed, but that's probably the exhaustion making it hard to keep up.

"Hi, Angella! Hi, Adora! I'm getting everything back in order!" Entrapta says enthusiastically. Adora glances down at the tool bench Entrapta was depositing tools on when they walked in. It's kind of a mess right now, but apparently Entrapta brought her own – custom-built, or at least modified – tools back with her already, so it's currently housing double what it should. Entrapta did say she was working on it, not that she was done.

"Of course. I see the mix-up with security hasn't slowed you down," Angella comments, trailing behind Adora at her dignified pace.

Adora snorts as Entrapta declares, "Nope!" grinning and rocking back and forth from her heels to her toes.

"Catra assured me you wouldn't be mad if I came back, so I'm here!" Entrapta adds on, gesturing vaguely at the garage space around her.

At the mention of Catra, Adora's gaze sticks on Entrapta hands, trying *valiantly* not to think about where they've been. Adora has never even seen Entrapta without her work gloves on, but she must take them off for sex, right?

"Mad?" Angella questions as Adora blushes and quickly looks away, towards anywhere but Entrapta. She casts her gaze to the side, intending to stare resolutely at the wall, and that's when she sees her.

Catra's grin is smug and predatory from her shaded perch on top of the shop cabinets. She's a good ten feet up and lounging effortlessly back against the garage wall. The conversation carries on behind them, but Adora barely registers it, lost entirely in Catra's gaze.

"*I know I ran off without much warning and I've learned that upsets people. I wasn't sure you would still need or want me.*"

"*Entrapta, there's always room for you here.*"

It all fades away, dimmed like the street noise usually is when she steps out of the club after hours of losing herself in pounding music. Catra smirked at her a lot yesterday, but there's something burning in her gaze now that goes even deeper than satisfaction.

"What's that?" Angella questions, snapping Adora out of her reverie in a way the conversation wrapping up behind them couldn't only because this could be something related to Catra's presence. When she forces herself to look away from Catra, she sees Angella has inclined her head towards something which could not be *more* Catra-related.

"My resume," Catra replies. Adora whips her head around in time to watch Catra push off the wall and drop from the cabinets with all the grace of the species that she is named after. Catra smirks, not at Adora, but at Angella over her shoulder, which probably shouldn't make Adora feel as indignant as it does, but she wants Catra looking at *her*.

"Y our resume?" Angella questions, sounding vaguely amused even if she's clearly confused. Adora is pretty sure she didn't know Catra was there until she spoke, but she isn't looking away from Catra again to check Angella's expression. Catra shrugs, crossing her arms and jerking her chin over towards where Melog is parked near the back of the garage, the silent subject of their conversation.

"It' s better than anything that has ever crossed your track before, and it's an original. Entrapta and I work well together . I doubt you need two new mechanics right now, but keep me in mind. As fun as racing is, my brain will start to rot if I don't get a little challenge here and there," Catra' s eyes slide from Angella to lock gazes with Adora, her blood immediately lighting up as Catra's smile curves up to show her fangs, "And I definitely don't get enough just racing. None of those idiots challenge me," she adds.

Oh, Adora will *challenge her* alright. She wants to shove her up against those cabinets. She wasn't ready for Catra to appear and it's making her even stupider around her than she usually is. She's just so infuriating, and cocky, and sexy, and smart, and fuck, Adora wants her. She's exhausted and probably doesn't have the energy for even one round right now, but it's easy to forget that when Catra stirs her blood so easily.

"I will take a look at our needs. Y ou're right that we're well-staffed, right now," Angella says, diplomatically . She knows how good Catra is without even having to touch the bike – it' s *Catra's* work that Adora has been racing on, after all – but she is right that they weren't ready for even Entrapta to come back. She might have her own reservations about bringing Catra in, too, for all Adora knows. Or maybe she would be happy to do it if it brought them back together. Maybe Adora can beg her into it.

Catra's here. Here! And she' s asking to be *hired*, to be here all the time. Or like, on a regular basis, at least. In Adora' s life and at the place she used to claim took Adora from her. Adora might be having heart palpitations.

"Catra, a word?" Adora asks, stepping around the workbenches and already reaching for Catra's hand as she crosses the expanse of the garage. Her voice is high, but she's barely holding it together. Catra grins, lop-sided, at her as she lets Adora take her wrist.

"Well, I suppose, since you're so desperate for m-" her smug drawl cuts off as Adora yanks her away from the wall to drag her behind her.

"She doesn't have clearance- Oh, never mind," Angella tries to call after them. Usually those abandoned calls follow Glimmer, but they have never fallen on more deaf ears. Adora marches out of the room with Catra *preening* behind her. She drags them around until she finds the door to one of the indoor track-observation rooms open.

They're only used during races and it is not a race day. They won't be interrupted here. Adora pulls Catra inside and then turns to close the door. As she reaches past Catra to close it, Catra throws her a wicked smile. The second the door has clicked shut, Catra's hands are on her head and pulling her in for a kiss. Adora groans, bracing her arm on the door and leaning in to kiss that *fuck me* smirk.

She wants to. Fuck, she wants to. They absolutely shouldn't here, but they definitely *can't* right now. They need to- Catra is *here* and as much as that lights her blood on fire, she needs answers before she gets so high on her hope that she spends the next three days crying from the crash.

She pulls back and Catra tries to chase her. Adora moans as Catra bites at her lower lip and pulls her back in with a sharp tug, her tongue licking back into Adora's mouth immediately.

"Catra," Adora manages to mumble into the kiss, trying to make her tone insistent, but she's so weak beneath Catra on a good day, and today started *bad*. Which is another reason they need to fucking talk. Catra releases a pleased growl and tugs her closer, reaching for Adora's free hand and pulling it around her own waist to encourage Adora to hold her. *Fuck*.

"We can do this if-" Catra cuts her off by kissing her before she can finish. She wants to kiss her so bad she *can't* stop herself from kissing back, but her heart is already hammering with worry. It doesn't take much to give her anxiety on days where she hasn't slept. "I need you to say a *few* words-"

Catra cuts her off before she can say *to assure me*, but this time she does it by forcefully pulling back from the kiss and startling Adora as she locks her burning gaze onto her own.

"Audio. Audit. Augment. Augur-"

"Are you listing off words alphabetically?" Adora asks, confused. Catra rolls her eyes, lolling her head back against the door to show off her fanged smirk.

"Entrapta listens to the dictionary at night. She started trying to subliminally teach her brain as a kid and now she can't fall asleep in a real bed without it," Catra tells her with obvious pride at having found a loophole in Adora's request. Adora has seen Entrapta fall asleep at her workbench many times – and even standing up once, not even waking when Bow barely caught her before she hit the floor – but she knows as well as anybody how hard it can be to sleep in a bed with a part of your routine that has always *been* there missing.

"Are you staying?" Adora blurts out before Catra can distract her with another kiss. Catra's ears twitch and she blinks back at her, eyes wide. Fuck, she's frozen and so is Adora. "I- Catra, last night *sucked*. Look at me," she doesn't need to gesture to any one part of herself to make it clear what she's talking about. Catra's gaze flicks between her eyebags, the giant hoodie she's hiding in because she just doesn't feel good, and her ponytail that isn't even centered and is missing a few locks because she couldn't be bothered to really fix it. That's her *hair*. The only thing she takes more pride in is her muscles – which are also currently hidden – and she couldn't be bothered to do even the bare minimum.

f you're going to be coming and going, Ican be happy with that because it's better than nothing, but Ineed to know . t was killing me all night not knowing when Iwas going to hear from you again." Catra stays silent. Adora's gaze is desperate where it remains locked on Catra's. f Iwas going to hear from you again,"she finally adds in a small, broken whisper. She didn't start being seriously tormented by those thoughts until it was nearing one A.M. h morning light –especially with morning light shining down on Catra' s stunned face –they seem stupid, but they did keep her up.

Catra swallows and she pushes off the door. Adora takes a reluctant step backwards, letting her hands fall as Catra turns and walks towards the large, curved windows overlooking the track. After a moment, Adora trails after her, hanging back a few feet and fidgeting with her hoodie pull-strings nervously.

f didn't plan that far ahead,"Catra admits after a moment. Adora snorts and pulls a little too far on one string, having to hurry to grab the other end before it gets sucked through the gromet and lost.

f guessed,"she replies. Catra shakes her head and turns around. Framed by the bright light streaming into the unlit room, she is a dark shape. Her ears stick out on either side of her head and bade Adora to reach up and pet them, but she stays where she is, squinting a little to make out Catra's expression.

f No, you don't understand. Iplanned *everything*. Until- until now," Catra tells her. Adora frowns, glancing back towards the door. Obviously Catra planned this. How else would she have shown up here? Catra registers her confusion. She reaches up and pushes her bangs out of her face, sighing. f don't just mean today , Adora. Yesterday. The night before. Running into you at the club every damn time."

W What?" Adora asks, her hands still now because her brain is occupied enough just trying to make sense of that. Y ou- Why? No, you couldn't have."Catra laughs, a little mirthful, and shakes her head.

"Yes, I did. Every time but the very first. Once I had Entrapta I could ask her about your new routine. She told me you always go to the same place and I already knew where that was. I've been there like a dozen times when you never even showed," Catra tells her. Adora's jaw drops. That doesn't make *sense*. The second time they ran into each other ended in Catra yelling she *hated* her. Why would she have sought her out, then? Just to make sure she knew?

"Why?" Adora asks, her voice a little more tremulous. Catra has a self-deprecating smile as she turns her head down and to the right, shaking it a little.

"Why do you fucking think, Adora? I was too mad to call, but I missed you," Catra says, shrugging her shoulders like that all makes sense. Adora's heartbeat seems to fill her entire body.

"Even that second time?" she asks, her voice quiet. Catra swallows, and then slowly, she looks back up and makes eye contact.

"Especially that second time. That's why I got so mad, because I I just wanted to give in, but I felt like you didn't care. I thought I was doomed to love you and never get back any of what I was willing to give you," Catra admits, her voice low. Adora draws in a breath and then propels herself forward, hands coming up to frame Catra's face as soon as she reaches her. She brushes her hair aside and strokes her cheeks as she pulls her in so their gazes can lock and there's nowhere else *to* look but at each other.

"I think I owe you ninety-six more *I love you*s and promises to show it," she manages, the lilt of a joke in her voice beneath all the emotion. Catra laughs, the sound a little choked, but she's smiling.

"You idiot," she says. Adora swallows.

"Your idiot. Still. Always. I know I fucked up, but I want to fix it. I want to treat you better," she promises. When Catra kisses her this time, she doesn't try to stop her. Adora wraps her arms around the small of her back, drawing her close. Catra grabs her arms and pulls her

even closer, leaning back so they stumble a few steps until Catra's back reaches the glass and they can lean back against the curve, still kissing. The embrace is desperate, but the longer it lasts, the louder a calming hum in the back of Adora's mind becomes.

Catra planned this. She wants Adora in her life more than she could have imagined.

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They end up breathless, Adora slumped in one of the observation deck seats and Catra in her lap, doing her level best to climb inside her hoodie with her. Adora is exhausted after all the turmoil, but it's a peaceful feeling now. She has her arm loosely around Catra and is absently rubbing a circle against her hip with her thumb.

"What changed?" she asks. She means last night – two days ago now, whatever, she barely slept last night so it all feels like one day – and she isn't sure that's obvious, but Catra doesn't ask her to clarify. She's silent for several long moments.

"Every time I did break and meet up with you, I don't know, you worked your way in. Getting stabbed definitely made me reconsider things. I planned to hunt you down so I could go home with you and see how you treated me. To finally know if you were going to do better, or..." she trails off, sighing. Adora reaches up with her other hand, just placing it on her shoulder in a silent show of comfort. Catra nuzzles into the collar of her hoodie. She's wearing her leather jacket again, but you wouldn't know it with how she's trying to steal Adora's body warmth.

"I know we both fucked up, okay? You were an asshole, and I didn't let you explain, and you wouldn't *listen* and didn't care how it made me feel- Ugh, but I also know you didn't mean it like that. Do n't you

dare think about pulling that kind of shit again, but" she trails of f again. Catra really doesn't like talking about emotions. Adora slides her hand up from her shoulder to cup the side of her head, holding her in place so she can turn and press a kiss to the base of Catra's ear.

"But I love you. And I'll show you right this time," she finishes for her . She loves Catra and she finally managed to convince her yesterday that she had the whole time. Catra sighs again, but this time there's a bit of a dreamy quality to it.

"Yeah. And I- I mean given the dumb fucking lengths I've been going to, I think it's pretty obvious how I still feel," Catra returns. Adora's heart does a skip that she knows Catra can feel, or at least hear, because her ears twitch along with it.

Adora kind of knows how Catra feels. I kind of. She *knows*, but…

"I love you," she says, and then after a long moment, Catra understands what she needs and the opening Adora is giving her.

"You, too," she murmurs back.

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"You never answered my question, you know ," Adora points out as they make their way back towards the garage, Catra tucked under her arm and seeming quite pleased to be there if the barely-perceptible purr she is giving is any indication. Catra scoffs.

"Good," she sniffs. Adora loves her. She's *stupidly* in love with her, brattiness and all. She's smiling as she pushes the garage door open.

"How often are you coming around? You know I'll clear out closet space for you right now," Adora asks. They've talked, some. Catra is ready – past ready – for them to be in each other's lives again as long as they take the time to listen to each other and *respect* each other. Adora is going to have to work on putting her foot in her mouth, but she's stubborn. She has the determination to do anything if it will get her back with Catra. Besides, she wants to do it. She wants to be a better girlfriend. She wants to listen to Catra and be listened to. It's something she needs when asking for anything is already hard for her.

Catra huffs at her side, ducking her head as they make their way back inside to find Entrapta still rearranging the shop – or maybe rearranging it again. Adora walks Catra over to an empty workbench Entrapta hasn't gotten to yet and drops her arm from her shoulders so she can help her to hop up and settle on it. Not that Catra *needs* help, but Adora's happy for an excuse to put her hands on her hips and then box her in afterwards, making pointed eye contact. Up on the bench, Catra is taller than her, but eventually she relents instead of just looking away.

"I'm not moving back in *tonight*. We need to talk more first, and you know how much I hate that, so it will probably take a bit. But I'll be there. Until we're okay again, I'll be here," Catra promises her, quietly, reaching up to cup her face and run her thumb over Adora's cheek. Adora's eyelids flutter, but she forces herself to hold Catra's gaze despite how she wants to melt.

"Can I call you? I know seeing each other every day might be a bit much but... could we?" she asks, because now she knows they stand so much closer to where she wants them – now she knows how they can work to get where they once were and then to somewhere *better* – she wants to ask every question she has, to get every piece of Catra she is willing to offer her. Catra laughs, her voice light and sparkling, just like the look in her eyes as she gazes down at Adora.

"We can try. And Adora?" the way she says the words has Adora drawing in a sharp breath. She's right to do it. Catra leans in, her lips lining up with Adora's ear. "Tonight, you can race me," her whisper drips with promise.

Oh, Adora's *awake*.

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Angella was missing from the garage when they made their way back, but when Adora does hunt her down – after reluctantly leaving Catra with Entrapta in the garage – Angella predictably refuses to let her on the track today despite the fact that Adora is doing *much* better than she was when she first got here. At least Adora gets her to clear Catra with security for future visits. She comes back to find Catra under Melog and Entrapta chattering a mile a minute as she recalibrates the free-roaming hydraulic lift she built before Adora joined the track. Entrapta is attached to it – she even named it Emily – but it was too big for her to take with her when she left. They seem to be *bonding* again if the way she keeps talking and humming to it is any indication.

Adora leans against Catra's tool cart and just watches her work on Melog for a bit, appreciating the view and handing her a tool whenever she asks for one.

"So. Swift Wind's around here somewhere, huh?" Catra asks, casually, her face hidden by Melog's engine because she's a dirty cheater who times things. Adora's face twitches and her hand braced on the edge of the cart tightens.

"Yeah," she replies, voice a little breathy. She swallows, trying to get herself together. "I mean, I can have him brought out, if you want,"

she offers, a hopeful lilt to her voice. Catra grunts, the sounds of tools not stopping on the other side.

"Not today . Im tuning up Melog while Ihave access to a proper garage. Eventually security's going to take issue with it," Catra tells her. Adora hums happily. *Not today* makes her just as happy as *not tonight* did yesterday. It' s a rejection, but a promise too.

"Y ou have clearance to come visit now. Idon't think they'll let you work on your own bike in here regularly, but you can come whenever you want," Adora promises her . Catra laughs, finally sliding back into view to throw Adora an amused smile.

"Princess, even *you* aren't allowed at the track whenever you want," she returns. Adora flushes, scuffing her foot on the floor a bit petulantly.

"Y eah, but that's for my own good,' or whatever . Listen, Im wearing Angella down," Adora defends.

"I doubt that! Angella is dif ficult to convince and all indications were that you were making no progress!" Entrapta pipes up, cheerily , from a few feet away where she's chasing Emily down as it slowly vrooms away. Adora pouts in her direction, sulking as Catra laughs again down on the floor.

"Y eah, well, eventually she has to get tired," Adora grumbles. Catra' s laughing tapers down to snickers and she sits up, reaching a hand towards Adora. Adora immediately lights up, reaching out and pulling her up. She *keeps* pulling and Catra stumbles into her arms with a roll of her eyes. "Hey , gorgeous," Adora greets, complaints forgotten now that she has Catra's face so close to hers. Catra's cheek dust pink beneath her freckles.

"Hey , Adora," she purrs back, because she knows what that voice does to Adora. That's playing *dirty*. Adora reaches down, picking Catra up and taking a few steps to set her up on the edge of the crowded workbench nearby. Catra has to tuck her tail in close to

avoid it hitting the clutter of tools, but she grins as Adora leans in and kisses her. They kind of made out on the other bench for a bit earlier, but now Entrapta has made that bench into an even bigger mess than this one and Adora is far from done enjoying Catra's presence.

"Could you hand me that wrench?" Entrapta pipes up from somewhere around hip height. Adora startles, pulling back and glancing down to find Entrapta thrown over Emily, apparently trying to hold her down, and holding her hand out expectantly. Adora blinks at her and Entrapta blinks back.

Catra reaches behind her and passes down the wrench before Adora has looked away from Entrapta. Entrapta brightens immediately, taking it from her hand and sticking her tongue out a little as she looks back down at Emily.

"Okay , now hold still and I'll fix you!" Entrapta declares to the robot, apparently completely unmoved by their positioning. Catra chuckles as she reaches up and directs Adora back to looking at her with a gentle hand on her jaw .

"Eyes on me, princess," Catra purrs to her . Adora lets out a breath that's almost a snort and then leans in, kissing Catra again. Okay, so whatever Catra and Entrapta have been up to doesn't seem to be any kind of problem for Entrapta. Not that Adora expected it to be, really, but she knows things are going to be antagonistic between her and Scorpia for a while, so she still kind of expected Entrapta to be annoyed by them being all… *this* in her space. Apparently it doesn't matter to Entrapta any more than it does when it's Mermista and Sea Hawk messing around before a race. As long as they don't break something, it will probably be fine.

"You know I'm always focused on you," Adora murmurs, kissing Catra again. Catra purrs softly and Adora melts, kissing her deeper, just so happy to have Catra beneath her hands again. Whenever she has the opportunity to be around her, Catra is always going to be the center of her attention, especially when she can hardly believe that

she's here again. Barring any more interruptions from Entrapta or errant robots, she doesn't plan on pulling away.

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It's late afternoon when Adora is finally ready to go home. Even if she wasn't allowed to practice today, she did have things to do. Catra sticks around, though. Mostly she hangs out with Entrapta in the garage, but she also wraps an arm around Adora and trails around the track with her for a while. When it comes time to go, Adora brings her motorcycle around so they can get a clean start off together, but she gets a little distracted seeing Catra perched on Melog for the first time in a year and ends up climbing off her own bike to go kiss her breathless before Catra puts her helmet on.

"Wow, can't even wait until we get home?" Catra teases as Adora pulls back with cheeks red from excitement. It sends a shiver through her to hear Catra refer to it like that so casually. She reaches up to tuck Catra's scruffy bangs behind her ear, stroking her cheek as she does so.

"I can't help it. I'm just so happy you're here," Adora breathes back. Predictably, the affection flusters Catra and she rolls her eyes as if that makes the blush on her cheeks invisible.

"Yeah, well, just don't expect me to become your umbrella girl or anything," Catra replies, rolling her eyes as she pulls back and hurries to pull on her helmet so she can hide behind her visor. Adora rolls her eyes as she gives herself one last moment to trail her hand over Catra – she's *sexy* on a bike – before she steps back and pulls on her own helmet.

"I know I'll be racing against you on the track before that happens," she promises. Catra flips up her visor just to throw Adora a smirk

before sealing it again and revving her engine.

"Don't worry, you get to jump straight to losing right now," she promises, and then she kicks off the ground. Adora scrambles to follow, but Catra pauses once she has her bike whipped around, giving Adora time to get in line with her. After all, while neither of them is above racing dirty when it's just for fun, it's more satisfying to brag about a race won fairly.

The moment they're lined up, they glance at each other, and even with darkened visors, they know each other's signals. They nod to each other and look forward. Adora takes in a breath and holds it for just a second, the timing a muscle memory that a year could never fade.

At the same moment, they blow out their synced breaths and take off. Catra's laugh echoes in the wind that overtakes them as they speed out into the streets. They go easy—really, Catra goes easy on *her*, not going for any tight weaves or sharp corners that force Adora to do the same to keep up—to compensate for Adora's lingering exhaustion and dulled reaction times, but the wind whipping around them and Catra's engine roaring beside her own is its own high.

When they reach the house, Catra will take a sharp corner at the last moment to win and Adora won't even protest. Instead, she'll pull off both their helmets as fast as she can and kiss Catra breathless. The price for losing is what it has always been: Catra gets what she wants in bed. That's a toll Adora is more than willing to pay.

Chapter End Notes

Fic notes are up over on my Tumblr. Hope y'all had fun!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!